DRAGON

SCREENPLAY

2026-10-21

SAMPLE PAGES. This screenplay was written for this app, as the pages its demo project is broken down from. It is not Ashwath Marimuthu's screenplay for Dragon (2025) and contains none of that film's dialogue — the scene structure follows the public account of the film, and every line, every action paragraph and all of the paperwork attached to it are invented for this sample. Delete the project, or edit any of it, and nothing is lost.

The dialogue is in Tanglish — Tamil in the Latin alphabet — and the slug lines, action and transitions are in English. That is what a Tamil unit actually shoots from, and it is the only arrangement in which the page count stays arithmetic: screenplay pagination is a fixed-width Courier grid, and this app's schedule, sides and budget are all derived from it.

INT. SCHOOL ASSEMBLY HALL, ASHOK NAGAR - DAY (2014)

Ceiling fans on long stems, turning at four different speeds. Under them, rows of folding chairs and a stage with eight staff on it.

A cloth banner behind the stage. PRIZE DAY 2014. The last digit sits lower than the other three.

A hundred and eighty students in white shirts. At the back, sixty parents standing, because the chairs ran out four rows in.

YOUNG RAGAVAN, 17, aisle seat, fifth row. He is not watching the stage.

He has a slip of paper folded into eighths, opened flat on his knee and angled away from the boy behind him.

On it, in his own handwriting: six subjects, six numbers, and a total at the bottom underlined twice.

He checks the total. He does not need to. He has been checking it since February.

At the lectern a teacher reads citations off index cards, flat, one after another, the way a register is read.

Students go up and come down. The applause starts before each name and stops cleanly after it.

Two of the standing parents at the back are his. The father has his hands behind his back. The mother holds a plastic cover with nothing in it.

The father has found the line with his son's name on it in the programme sheet, and keeps his thumb on it.

On stage, a staff member opens a flat box. Inside, a gold medal on a folded ribbon.

The teacher at the lectern turns an index card over and reads both sides of it.

The citation, flat: highest aggregate in the district. Mathematics, physics, chemistry. No rounding, no moderation.

Then the name.

Young Ragavan folds the slip back into eighths and puts it in his shirt pocket before he stands up.

He walks up the aisle. He does not look at the rows. A boy puts a hand out for him to slap and he misses it, because he has not seen it.

Six steps up to the stage. He takes them one at a time.

The medal goes over his head. The ribbon catches on his ear and he straightens it himself.

He shakes four hands in the order he was given in rehearsal, and he gets the order right.

Applause. It runs longer than the ones before it, and he stands inside it without doing anything with his face.

The teacher turns the microphone towards him. This is not in the programme.

Young Ragavan looks at it for a moment.

YOUNG RAGAVAN
Nandri, sir.

He steps back. The teacher moves the microphone closer again, smiling, waiting for the rest of it.

There is no rest of it.

YOUNG RAGAVAN
(to the hall)
Physics-la naalu mark poachu.
Question nine.

The hall laughs. He has not made a joke, and he does not know why they are laughing.

He goes down the six steps and back along the aisle to the fifth row.

At the back, the father has taken his hands out from behind his back.

The mother is not watching the stage either. She is looking along the row of parents beside her, one at a time, in case any of them missed it.

Young Ragavan sits. He takes the slip out of his pocket and unfolds it on his knee.

Under his own total he writes the district figure the teacher read out, and draws a line between them.

They are the same number.

He puts the slip away. He does not take the medal off.

The next citation begins. The hall settles. Nobody is looking at him any more, and he does not appear to need them to.

He opens the flat box on his knee, closes it, opens it again.

Two rows behind him, a boy is already asking somebody what the medal is worth.

Young Ragavan does not turn around.

Through the open doors at the back of the hall: white afternoon on a concrete yard, and a watchman folding a chair.

CUT TO:

EXT. RAGAVAN'S HOUSE, VILLIVAKKAM - DAY (2014)

A narrow street. A house with a gate, and a strip of cement in front of it wide enough for two people to stand on.

YOUNG RAGAVAN is on the strip holding a stack of college prospectuses against his chest, because nobody has told him to put it down.

RAGAVAN'S FATHER, fifties, stands in the open gate in a shirt ironed for the occasion. The application forms are in his hand.

RAGAVAN'S MOTHER is half inside the doorway, where she can hear everything and be seen doing nothing.

Twelve neighbours have come out for this. Two of them have brought their own chairs.

A boy on a two-wheeler slows, understands what is happening, and does not stop.

RAGAVAN'S FATHER
Mudhalla engineering.

He says it to the street, not to his son.

RAGAVAN'S FATHER
Naalu varusham. Break illa, second attempt illa.

RAGAVAN'S FATHER
Apparam masters. Veliya. America, Germany, enga seat kedaikkudho anga.

One of the neighbours repeats the word outside to the neighbour standing next to him.

RAGAVAN'S FATHER
Apparam kalyanam. Veedu kalyanathukku munnadi mudiyanum, kalyanathukku appuram illa.

He turns the forms over so the printed side faces the street.

RAGAVAN'S FATHER
Moonu vishayam. Indha order-la.

A neighbour asks what the fees are. The father answers a different question, about the college placement record, and the neighbour takes it.

RAGAVAN'S MOTHER
Mottai maadi innum mudiyala.

She says it to nobody in particular. The father does not turn around.

RAGAVAN'S FATHER
Adhu mudiyum.

RAGAVAN'S MOTHER
Kalyanathukkulla?

RAGAVAN'S FATHER
Kalyanathukkulla.

Young Ragavan moves the prospectus stack from one arm to the other.

YOUNG RAGAVAN
Naan onnu vechukkalama?

The father hands him the forms instead. The medal box sits on the gate pillar, where somebody put it down and left it.

RAGAVAN'S FATHER
(to the street)
Poana vaaram medal vaangiirukkan.

The neighbours already know. They say so, and congratulate him again anyway.

Young Ragavan looks at the forms. Three sheets. His name is filled in on all three already, in his father's handwriting.

The father puts a hand flat on his son's back, not a push but the shape of one, and the boy goes in through the gate.

The neighbours stay. One of them picks up the medal box, opens it, and passes it along.

The box goes down the line, hand to hand, and comes back closed.

CUT TO:

EXT. ENGINEERING COLLEGE - FRONT BLOCK - DAY

The front block: four storeys, a clock on the face of it nine minutes fast, and a hundred and twenty students moving under it.

A college bus swings in and unloads. Two security men work the gate, checking lanyards with the energy of men who have never once found anything.

RAGAVAN, 26, comes through on foot. No lanyard. The walk of a man who is early.

He is not early. He is nineteen days into a semester that started in June.

The first security man puts a hand up.

RAGAVAN
Mozhangaal epdi irukku, anna?

The hand comes down. Ragavan is past the gate while the answer is still being given, and he takes the answer over his shoulder and nods in the right place.

ANBU, the same age, comes out of the shade of the block to meet him, carrying a lab record with a damp cover sheet.

ANBU
Pathinonnu maniku list-a
poduvaanga.

RAGAVAN
Enna list?

ANBU
Enna list-nu unakke theriyum.

RAGAVAN
Record sign vaangittiya?

Anbu lets it go, the way you let go of something you have let go of before.

They walk. The front block belongs to Ragavan in a way that it does not belong to anybody who is only passing through it.

A boy stops him for a signature on a tour form. Ragavan signs it, in the box marked staff.

RAGAVAN
Naan countersign pannitennu sollu.

Two girls on the steps want to know whether the symposium is happening. He says it is, and makes a note on the back of his hand, because it is not.

A boy coming down the steps puts money into his shirt pocket without being asked. Another one takes some out of it, also without being asked.

ANBU
Adhu yaaroda?

RAGAVAN
Edhu dhaan yaaroda, da.

Anbu writes something in the back of the lab record. Not for the record. For himself.

The clock on the front block says twenty past nine. Everybody under it subtracts nine minutes without thinking about it.

ANBU
Moonu varushama andha clock keezhadhaan ulla varom.

RAGAVAN
Onbadhukku mela edhavadhu thappa poiruka?

ANBU
Adhu sariyaa irukkardhu kidaiyadhu.

Ragavan has already stopped listening, because a staff member is coming down the steps with a folder under his arm.

He turns, puts himself in the man's path, and is talking before the man has decided whether to stop.

RAGAVAN
Sir. Second batch oda lab list. Ennkitta irukku sir. Rendu maniku office-ku kondu varen.

The staff member nods and goes. Ragavan does not have the lab list, has never seen the lab list, and now has until two o clock.

ANBU
Unkitta list illa.

RAGAVAN
Rendu maniku irukkum.

A third year with a camera wants a photograph. Ragavan steps in, puts an arm round him, and is gone before the second frame.

Under the arch, a notice board. A clerk is unlocking the glass with a key on a length of string.

The glass comes open. The clerk puts up one sheet and smooths it down with the side of his hand.

Students begin to gather. Not many of them, at first.

ANBU
Pathinonnu-nu sonnen.

Ragavan is watching the clerk, and the clerk is looking for the right key to lock up with.

RAGAVAN
Enna avasaram? Week-pooravum anga dhaan irukkum.

ANBU
Week-pooravum anga dhaan irukkum.

He means it a different way. Ragavan takes it the way it was given and not the way it was meant.

Behind them the corridor fills. Somebody says his name, then two people say it, and then it is a sound rather than a name.

He puts a hand up to all of it without looking to see who it was for.

CUT TO:

INT. COLLEGE CORRIDOR - ARREARS BOARD - DAY

A corridor lit by tubes, with a notice board behind glass at the end of it.

Forty students in front of the glass, in the shape a crowd takes when it has formed around one person.

The person is RAGAVAN. His back is to the board and he is reading it over his own shoulder, for the benefit of the room.

Behind the glass: ARREAR SUBJECTS, REGISTERED CANDIDATES. Four columns, two hundred names, a run of subject codes against each one.

Near the bottom, his name, and beside it a run of codes long enough that the clerk has had to carry it onto a second line.

RAGAVAN
(reading, theatrical)
Onnu.

He taps the glass once for each of them.

RAGAVAN

Rendu. Moonu. Naalu dhaan drawing, adhu subject illa da, adhu oru hobby.

The crowd gives him the laugh. He takes it and keeps going.

RAGAVAN
Anju. Aaru. Ezhu. Ezhu-ku poanen.

ANBU
First class-ku mattum poana.

RAGAVAN
Attendance edukkara class adhu dhaan aachu.

Bigger laugh. A boy at the back writes the codes on his wrist, not for Ragavan, for a bet somebody in the hostel is running.

RAGAVAN
Ettu. Onbadhu. Patthu.

He stops on ten with his palm flat on the glass, like a man finishing a speech, and the crowd gives him the end of it.

RAGAVAN
Patthu. Double figures. Indha college-la yaarum naalaam varushathukku munnadi anga poanadhilla.

Applause, in a corridor, for a list of failures. He accepts it with one hand.

Anbu is not in the crowd. He is at the edge of it, close to the glass, reading the second line of codes carried over under the first.

ANBU
Pathinonnu.

Not loud. He does not have to be.

RAGAVAN
Patthu.

ANBU
December practical rendaavadhu line-la irukku. Rendaavadhu line-a yaarum padikkaradhilla.

He puts a finger on the glass under it and leaves the finger there.

The crowd leans in to look. One of them counts under his breath and arrives where Anbu arrived.

RAGAVAN
(to the crowd)
Ivan nalla nyaabagam vechirukkara mosamaana friend.

The laugh comes back, smaller. The crowd begins to come apart into its parts: lectures, canteen, somewhere else.

ANBU
Pathinonnu.

RAGAVAN
Thirupi sollu, pannerandu aagidum.

ANBU
Adhu apdilaam velai seyyadhu.

The last of them go. The corridor empties out to its own length again.

Ragavan stays in front of the glass a second longer than the performance needed.

He looks at the second line. Then he puts his hand over the reflection of his own face and moves off.

CUT TO:

INT. COLLEGE CANTEEN - DAY

Seventy students, four staff, and a ceiling fan moving the smell of oil from one end of the room to the other.

Steel tumblers going down on steel tables. A queue at the counter that is not a queue.

RAGAVAN has the corner table, which is the good table, and he did not get there first.

Two boys stand at the end of it waiting for a verdict on something. ANBU sits across from him with a notebook open.

The notebook is ruled, and it has dates down the left hand side.

RAGAVAN
(to the two boys)
Aalukku ambadhu, rendu maniku yaaru adhula okkaandhirukkaango avangaluku seat. Adhu rule illa, adhu nadakka poradhu adhu dhaan.

They accept it. It is not a good verdict but it was delivered quickly.

He has a tea in front of him that he has not paid for. The counter man brought it over.

ANBU
Rendu mani.

RAGAVAN
Hm.

ANBU
Lab list. Second batch. Adhu unkitta irukkunu oru staff-kitta sonniye.

RAGAVAN
Unkitta pen irukka?

Anbu gives him the pen. Ragavan writes LAB LIST on his hand under the first thing written on his hand, and gives the pen back.

ANBU
Andha kai-la naalu vishayam irukku.

RAGAVAN
Periya kai da.

Anbu turns a page and writes the four things down properly, with the date, because one of them has to.

A boy leans in to ask whether the symposium is happening. Ragavan says yes without turning his head.

ANBU
Adhu nadakkala.

RAGAVAN
Innum nadakkala.

The room is aware of the corner table the way a room is aware of a window.

KEERTHI comes in with a record notebook under her arm, takes a tumbler of water, and sits at the end of their table because it is the only place left.

She does not sit down as a guest. She sits down and starts reading.

RAGAVAN
Nee second batch-la dhaane.

KEERTHI
Aama.

RAGAVAN
Appo unkitta lab list irukkum.

KEERTHI
Oru list-la en per irukku. Adhu veru vishayam.

RAGAVAN
Adhuvum oru aarambam.

She looks up for the first time. He has already turned his hand over so that she cannot read it.

KEERTHI
Second batch list yen unakku venum?

RAGAVAN
Yaarukku edhu yen venum?

KEERTHI
Adhu bathil illa, adhu innum chinna kelvi.

Anbu, without looking up from the notebook, makes a mark in the margin. He has heard this before and he has a mark for it.

RAGAVAN
Onbadhu maniku oruthankitta onnu irukkunu sonnen. Ippo rendu mani.

KEERTHI
Apparam enna?

RAGAVAN
Apparam adhu ennakitta irukkum.

KEERTHI
Illa. Apparam. Ellathukkum apparam.

It is an ordinary question in a canteen. Nothing in the room changes. He answers it the way he answers everything, at speed.

RAGAVAN
Campus placement. Apparam veliyur.
Apparam vandhu indha canteen-a
vaangi nalla fan vechu tharen.

The nearest four tables laugh. One of them repeats the part about the fan.

Keerthi does not laugh. She is looking at him the way you look at a sum that has come out too easily.

KEERTHI
Ethana arrear?

The table goes quiet, delightedly, the way a room goes quiet when somebody has walked into something.

RAGAVAN
Avan-kitta kelu. Avan vechirukkan.

ANBU
(not looking up)
Pathinonnu.

The canteen takes it like a punchline. Somebody at the far end who cannot have heard the question repeats the number anyway.

Tumblers go up. Eleven is a good number in a canteen at half past one.

Keerthi does not take it as a joke, and does not say that she is not taking it as a joke.

KEERTHI
Ethanaila pathinonnu?

Nobody at the table has that figure. Anbu turns back three pages to look for it.

Keerthi picks up her record notebook and goes to class, which started four minutes ago.

CUT TO:

EXT. ENGINEERING COLLEGE - QUAD - DAY

A quad with a stage end to it: a department banner strung between two pillars, and a mic stand in front of it.

The banner says DEPARTMENT SYMPOSIUM, and under that a date, which is this Friday.

A hundred and fifty students are in the quad, mostly because it is between classes and the quad is where you go.

Nobody is on the stage end. Nobody has been given the job of being on the stage end.

THE CLASSMATE, quiet, a folded jacket over one arm, is working along the edge of the crowd towards the staircase.

RAGAVAN cuts him off without appearing to.

RAGAVAN
Nalla jacket da.

THE CLASSMATE
Adhu en cousin-oda. Kalyanam Sunday anniku.

RAGAVAN
Sunday-ku innum naalu naal irukku.

That is not an argument. It is said as though it were one, and the jacket changes arms.

Black, with something stitched across the whole of the back in gold thread, which neither of them looks at.

THE CLASSMATE
Friday-ku thirupi kudu.

RAGAVAN
Friday.

Ragavan puts it on while walking away, which is the only way he puts anything on.

ANBU watches the handover from the steps and writes a line in the notebook without opening it all the way.

Ragavan arrives at the mic stand. He taps the mic twice. It is live, which surprises everybody including him.

RAGAVAN
Nanbargale. Good afternoon.

A hundred and fifty people turn round for no reason except that somebody has used the microphone.

RAGAVAN
Symposium Friday nadakkudhu. Naan dhaan coordinator.

He is not the coordinator. There is no coordinator. The department is four days away from finding this out.

RAGAVAN
Rendu event, veliyilerundhu oru guest, appuram second half-la ellarukkum tea.

Applause. The tea is the part they applaud.

RAGAVAN
Naalu maniku registration. Ennkitta register pannunga, office-la vendam. Office-la thodachiduvaanga.

A boy shouts a question about whether the guest from outside is confirmed.

RAGAVAN
Edhavadhu confirm aagiruka? Nee confirm-a?

The laugh he gets for that is the biggest of the day, and it buys him the next four days.

He steps back off the mic and turns to come down from the stage end.

The quad sees the back of the jacket for the first time: a dragon in gold thread, head at the shoulder, tail down to the hem.

Somebody at the front says it out loud. Somebody at the back says it louder.

In eight seconds it is a hundred and fifty people saying one word in time, because a quad will do that with any word at all.

Ragavan stops. He does not look confused for longer than it takes him to decide.

Then he turns back, takes the mic off the stand, and gives them the dragon properly: arms out, shoulders square, the whole back of the jacket.

The quad comes apart. Phones go up. A hundred and fifty people are now calling him something that is not his name.

The classmate is at the edge of it on the staircase, watching a jacket that is due at a wedding on Sunday.

THE CLASSMATE
(to nobody)
Friday.

He goes up the stairs. Nobody follows him and nobody asks him anything.

Anbu comes down through the crowd as it breaks up, and the new name reaches him three or four times on the way.

ANBU
Unakku oru per kuduthirukkaanga.

RAGAVAN
Enakku oru Friday kuduthirukkaanga.

ANBU
Adhaiyum kai-la ezhudhikko.

Ragavan looks at his hand. Four things, and the ink has gone in the heat.

RAGAVAN
Innaiku number enna?

ANBU
Nethu enna irundhudho adhe dhaan.
Adhu thaana nagaradhu.

Ragavan goes off across the quad in somebody else's jacket, and every second person in it knows him.

Not one of them could say what he is studying.

CUT TO:

INT. DEAN'S OFFICE - DAY

An office with nothing personal in it. A desk, a lamp with a green shade, two chairs, and a cupboard of files that goes up to the ceiling.

A CLERK at a side table stamps a page, turns it, stamps the next one. He does not look up once in the whole scene.

THE DEAN, sixties, is reading a student file. He has been reading it for some time.

RAGAVAN comes in. The jacket is gone. The shirt is tucked in, which is itself a performance.

THE DEAN
(not looking up)
Okkaru.

Ragavan sits. He puts his hands where they can be seen, which he has thought about.

The dean turns the file round and slides one sheet across it. A tour form. A signature in the box marked staff.

THE DEAN
Adhu yaaroda signature?

RAGAVAN
Sir, andha form Thursday varaikkum office-leye kedakkum, pasanga already bus-ukku kaasu kuduthuttaanga.

THE DEAN
Adhu yaaroda signature?

RAGAVAN
Bus dhaan problem. Bus-a naan sari pannitten.

The dean takes the sheet back and puts it in the file, in its place, in order.

THE DEAN
Adhu rendu bathil, rendumay naan ketta bathil illai.

RAGAVAN
Ennudhu, sir.

THE DEAN
Aamaam.

He opens the file near the front and reads off it with no weight on it at all.

THE DEAN
School record. Rendaayirathu padhinaalu. District first, moonu subject, moderation illai.

THE DEAN
Indha vaaram andha varia onbadhu thadava padichirukken.

RAGAVAN
Oru variku onbadhu adhigam, sir.

THE DEAN
Adhukku apparam file chinnadhu.

RAGAVAN
Sir. Placement drive November maasam varudhu.

THE DEAN
Aamaam.

RAGAVAN
Arrear zero irundha dhaan adhula okkaralaam. Apdiyum en per-a serunga.

He says it cleanly. It is the thing he came for, and he has got to it inside four minutes.

THE DEAN
Illai.

RAGAVAN
Ethana-nu neenga kekkave illa.

THE DEAN
Pathinonnu.

He did not have to open the file to get it.

RAGAVAN
Sir, inga varra company arrear sheet padikkaradhilla. Patthu nimisham oru aal kooda okkaandhu pesuvaanga.

THE DEAN
Theriyum. Adhu dhaan en siramam.

THE DEAN
Nee indha room-la anju nimisham irukke. Enakku naalu vilakkam kuduthe, adhula rendai mattum nambinen.

THE DEAN
Adhu entha rendu-nu, solra podhey unakku theriyum.

Ragavan does not answer. It is the first question today that has not had a better question underneath it.

THE DEAN
Naan marukkaradhu un mark-a illai. Mark-a pathi vaadhaadalaam. Mark-ukku oru committee irukku.

THE DEAN
Naan marukkaradhu unnai.

The lamp. The stamp. The cupboard of files going all the way up to the ceiling.

THE DEAN
Andha chair-la okkara ovvoru paiyanum enakku unmai illadha onnai solraan. Sollumbodhey naan nambura oruthan nee mattum dhaan.

RAGAVAN
Adhu apmaanam illa, sir.

THE DEAN
Illai. Adhu dhaan kaaranam.

THE DEAN
Edhayaavadhu vikkara aalukku adhu oru varam. En per irukkara form-la adhu oru aabathu. Un keezha enaala sign panna mudiyaadhu.

Ragavan sits with that. Outside, a bell, and a corridor beginning to fill.

THE DEAN
Sari. Indha term moonu maasam.

He writes a date on a slip and turns it round, the same way he turned the tour form round.

THE DEAN
Andha thediku ulla pathinonnaiyum clear pannu, naane un per-a drive-la serkkiren. Nee kondu varradhu unmaiyaa irundha, naan sign panren.

RAGAVAN
Andha pathinonnula rendu onne paper, rendu code-la. Office adhai ipovarai sari pannave illa.

THE DEAN
Appo onbadhu, moonu maasathula.

Ragavan stands. At the door he turns, because he has never once left a room without trying it one more time.

RAGAVAN
Sir. Naan clear panniten-na, neenga sonnadhu unga nyaabagam irukkuma?

THE DEAN
Naan adhai ezhudhi vechiruppen.

He has. He is writing it into the file while he says it.

Ragavan goes. The clerk stamps. The dean turns the page.

CUT TO:

INT. MEN'S HOSTEL ROOM - NIGHT

One tube light. Two cots, a table fan turning on a stool, and a window grille laying lines across the floor.

ANBU is on the near cot with a stack of mark sheets, in order, squared off. He has been to the office for these.

RAGAVAN is at the window, half out of it, negotiating tea for a hundred and fifty people with a man who has already said no.

RAGAVAN
(into the phone)
Friday naalu mani. Free-ya kekkala. Apparam kudunga-nu dhaan kekkiren.

The jacket hangs on the back of the chair with the dragon facing the room.

RAGAVAN
Appo munnuru. Appo irunooru ambadhu, oru varushathukku whole department-aiyum anuppi vekkiren.

He hangs up. He has got it. He makes no face about it; for him it was never in doubt.

ANBU
Naan office-ku poanen.

RAGAVAN
Nee poagavey thevai illa.

ANBU
Clerk full sheet-a kuduthaan. Board illa. Sheet.

He lays the mark sheets on the floor between the cots, in a line, so that all of them can be seen at once.

ANBU
Onnu. Engineering mathematics three. Rendu attempt.

ANBU
Rendu. Thermodynamics. Moonu attempt. Kadaisi thadava naalu mark-la thaan vizhundhutte.

RAGAVAN
Naalu mark.

ANBU
Naalu mark. Moonu. Fluid mechanics. Adhula nee okkaravey illa.

RAGAVAN
(still at the window)
Tea kaaran library pinnadi kadai vechirukkavan dhaana?

ANBU
Naalu. Machine drawing. Anju. Strength of materials.

ANBU
Aaru, ezhu, ettu poana varusha lab practical. Batch-oda serndhu lab-la thirumba panna vendum.

ANBU
Onbadhum patthum nee avasarathula register panni oru naal kooda attend pannadha elective.

ANBU
Pathinonnu December practical. Adhukku fee undu, andha fee August-leye mudinjidichu.

Ragavan comes away from the window. He steps over the line of mark sheets rather than round it, and sits on his own cot.

ANBU
Moonu maasam-nna pannerandu week. Pathinonnu paper. Monday aarambichaa aaru first sitting-leye clear aagidum.

ANBU
Lab dhaan problem. Oru lab-ku batch venum, batch-ku oru staff signature venum.

He has made a timetable. He turns the notebook round so that Ragavan can see it. Twelve weeks across, eleven lines down, the boxes ruled.

Ragavan looks at it for about as long as it takes to read the heading.

RAGAVAN
Naan adhai panna poradhilla.

The fan turns. The grille lines move one notch across the floor.

ANBU
Entha part?

RAGAVAN
Edhuvume.

Anbu waits. This is the place in the evening where the argument goes, and he has left room for it.

Ragavan takes his shirt off, hangs it on the chair over the jacket, and lies down.

ANBU
Unakku moonu maasam irukku.

RAGAVAN
December-ku naan velaiku poiruppen.

ANBU
Enga velai?

RAGAVAN

Rendaam varushathula lab-ku poanen-nu nirupikka sollaadha edho oru edathula.

ANBU
Ellaa edathiliyum keppaanga.

RAGAVAN
Appo ellaa edathukkum bathil.

That is the whole debate. It has taken ninety seconds and he has not raised his voice or sat up.

ANBU
Ragava.

Nothing. Either he is asleep, or he has decided to be.

Anbu puts the light out, and then puts it back on, and picks the mark sheets up off the floor in order.

He folds the timetable into the back of the notebook. Somebody has to keep it.

CUT TO:

INT. COLLEGE CANTEEN - DAY

Late afternoon. Forty-five students, most of the tables empty, the counter shutter half down.

KEERTHI is at a small table against the wall with her record notebook open and a ruler laid on it.

She is copying a set of readings off a sheet of paper that is not hers, and she is not pretending otherwise.

RAGAVAN sits down opposite her. Not the corner table. This one.

RAGAVAN
Andha paper-la irukkaradhu un handwriting illa.

KEERTHI
Illa. Enga batch-la meter velai seyyala. Idhu adhukku munnadi batch-oda reading.

RAGAVAN

Meter velai seyyala-nu avankitta sollirukkalaame.

KEERTHI
Sonnen. Avanukku reading venum.

She rules a line under the last row and turns to the back page, which has a box on it for a staff signature. The box is empty.

RAGAVAN
Inga kudu. Aaru maniku adhu sign aagi irukkum.

It is offered the way you offer somebody a lift. No weight on it at all.

KEERTHI
Vendam.

RAGAVAN
Avan oru naalaiku nalubadhu sign panraan, onnu kooda padikkaradhilla.

KEERTHI
Appo queue-la nikkaradhula enakku onnum poagaadhu.

She closes the record on her finger. It is the first time she has stopped working since he sat down.

KEERTHI
Nee enna aaga poare?

RAGAVAN
Panakkaaran.

KEERTHI
Adhu number. Naan enna-nu ketten.

RAGAVAN
Keezha pathinonnu per vechirukkara project manager, oru glass room-la, lift unkitta pesura oru tower-la.

It is a good answer. It is quick, it has a detail in it, and it is the kind of thing a room repeats.

There is no room. There are two of them and a shutter coming down.

KEERTHI
Thirupi sollu.

RAGAVAN
Enna?

KEERTHI
Adhe vishayathai thirupi sollu.
Tower-um lift-um.

He starts it. It comes out in a different order, with a different number in it, and he hears that happen.

KEERTHI
Mudhalla onbadhu per-nu sonne.

RAGAVAN
Pathinonnu nalla number.

KEERTHI
Adhu un number.

He laughs, properly, because it is funny, and because she has not said it to hurt him.

KEERTHI
Unakku enna kedaikkum-nu naan kekkala.

KEERTHI
Nee enna aaga poare-nu dhaan kekkiren.

Three tables away a steel tumbler goes over and rolls. Neither of them turns to look at it.

This is the longest Ragavan has gone inside a conversation without saying anything.

RAGAVAN
Idhuvarai canteen-la yaarum adha ennakitta kettadhilla.

KEERTHI
Adhuvum bathil illa.

She opens the record again and goes back to the readings. The ruler goes down. The next row starts.

KEERTHI
En bus aaru maniku.

And that is the end of it. She does not look up again, and he stays at the table a while longer, which he has never done.

CUT TO:

EXT. ENGINEERING COLLEGE - QUAD - DUSK

The quad at the last of the light. Friday's banner is down at one corner and nobody has taken it the rest of the way.

Thirty students crossing it, going home, in the loose order of the end of a day.

KEERTHI is at the cycle stand with a bicycle up on its stand, working a lock that does not want to come.

RAGAVAN comes across the quad with a record notebook in his hand. Hers.

He holds it out. The back page is open. The box has a signature in it, and a date.

KEERTHI
Vendam-nu sonnen.

RAGAVAN
Queue-la nikkaradhula onnum poagaadhu-nu nee sonne. Unakku onnum poagala. Naan dhaan ninnen.

KEERTHI
Naan sonna vaakkiyam adhu illa.

RAGAVAN
Idhu innum nallaa irukku.

The lock comes free. She winds the chain round the carrier without taking the record out of his hand.

KEERTHI
Avan adha padichaara?

RAGAVAN
En mugathai padichaan.

KEERTHI
Appo en record-la irukkara reading-a un mugathai paatha oruthan pass pannirukkaan.

Ragavan has no answer ready, because it is not an accusation. It is his own sentence read back to him.

He puts the record down on the carrier of the bicycle rather than into her hand.

A boy crossing the quad calls the new name at him. Ragavan puts a hand up without turning, and Keerthi watches him do it.

KEERTHI
Unnai apdi kooppida aarambichittaanga.

RAGAVAN
Adhu free per. Adhukku naan onnume pannala.

KEERTHI
Enakku kovam illa. Nee adhai dhaan thedra, adhu anga illa.

She is not. That is the difficulty.

KEERTHI
Monday adhai submit panren. Naalaiku poi puthu page-la sariyaa thirumba sign vaangikkalaam.

RAGAVAN
Adhu adhe signature dhaan.

KEERTHI
Adhu adhe page illa.

Behind the block the generator starts. The lights along the quad come on one row at a time, late.

KEERTHI
Canteen-la ketta kelvi.

RAGAVAN
Ennkitta bathil irukku.

KEERTHI
Unkitta naalu irukku. Adhula moonu naan ketturukken.

She takes the bicycle off its stand. The record sits open on the carrier, and the pages move in the wind that comes up at this hour.

KEERTHI
Monday sollu. Ippo vendam, avasaramaavum vendam.

RAGAVAN
Monday.

KEERTHI
Veru yaarukkitta-yo solli vechadha vendam.

She goes. She does not ride until she is out of the quad, which takes a while, and he watches the whole of it.

The record stays open on the carrier all the way to the gate.

Ragavan stands in the quad with the lights coming on behind him, working out what Monday is going to need.

Not what he is going to be. What Monday is going to need.

CUT TO:

INT. EXAM HALL, COLLEGE - DAY

A long hall, sixty desks in six rows, a wall clock over the board at the front, and four invigilators who have done this many times.

On every desk: one answer booklet, numbered in the top corner, and a hall ticket.

Ten past nine. Fifty-nine candidates. One empty desk in the fourth row.

RAGAVAN comes in at twelve minutes past, without hurrying, carrying a hall ticket and nothing else.

An invigilator begins the sentence about late entry. Ragavan gets to him first.

RAGAVAN
Sir, gate-la second block-ku anuppinaanga. Second block inga anuppicha. Yaaro nanooru ticket-la thappaana room print pannirukkaanga.

It is not true, and it is the kind of thing that is so often true that the invigilator waves him to the desk.

He sits down. He has no pen.

Insert: the hall ticket. Name, register number, and under it a printed column of subject codes. Eleven of them.

He folds the ticket so that the column is inside the fold, and puts it under the booklet.

Two rows ahead and one across, THE CLASSMATE is already writing. He started at nine.

ANBU is at the end of the second row, sitting his own paper, which he will pass.

Ragavan taps the shoulder in front of him and is handed a pen without a word being said by either of them.

The booklets open. The question paper goes face down and then face up through the whole hall at once, like a flock turning.

Ragavan reads question one.

He reads it again.

He writes his register number in the box. He writes it well. He writes it twice, once in numerals and once in words, which is not asked for.

Then he writes out the question in full in his own handwriting, because it fills a quarter of a page and it is the only sentence on the paper he is sure of.

Twenty past nine.

He looks up, and the hall becomes a different problem, and he is very good at this one.

He coughs once. Four rows away a boy coughs back twice.

A water bottle travels the back row hand to hand with a rolled strip of paper held against it under the thumb.

The strip is question four. By the time it reaches the window it has been read by nine people.

An invigilator walks the aisle. The bottle stops being a bottle and becomes somebody's drink.

Ragavan is writing furiously when the man passes him, and writing nothing at all when the man has gone.

He puts a hand up.

RAGAVAN
Sir. Indha desk-ku oru kaal kammi sir. Mothha row-kume satham panniruchu.

It is not. He has been rocking it for four minutes to prove that it is.

He is moved three desks forward, beside a boy from the regular batch who has a full page already written.

He carries his booklet across the hall in front of sixty people like a man being promoted.

The boy covers his page with a forearm. Ragavan does not look at it once, and the boy keeps the forearm there for three hours.

He puts a hand up again.

RAGAVAN
Sir. Additional sheet.

He is given one. He has not filled the first.

He ties it in with the string anyway, because a man tying in an additional sheet at half past nine is a man who is doing well.

Three desks notice. The news goes out across the hall the way it does, without anybody turning round.

Anbu, at the end of the second row, does not look up at all.

Half past ten. The classmate puts his pen down, reads his own paper back, and picks it up again to correct one word.

Ragavan watches him do it.

Insert: the number in the corner of the classmate's booklet. Then the number in the corner of his own.

Two numbers. In this hall every answer booklet is a number, and once it is collected it is only a number.

Ragavan puts a finger on his own corner and holds it there.

Then an invigilator turns his way, and he goes back to copying out question three in longhand.

Eleven o’clock. The hall has gone quiet the way it does in the last hour, when the people who can do it are doing it.

He has four pages. Three of them are the questions, copied.

The fourth has a diagram on it that is correct, and labelled, and from the wrong subject.

Twelve. The invigilators start collecting at the front.

The classmate hands his in and goes, and is out of the room before anybody can ask him what he put for question four.

Ragavan unties his additional sheet and ties it in a second time, so that it will be seen being tied.

The booklet goes. The invigilator does not look at it. Nobody looks at it. It joins a stack of sixty.

The hall empties in a noise. Ragavan is in the middle of the noise, and the middle of it is where he belongs.

Somebody asks him how it went. He makes a face and gets a laugh out of a doorway full of people.

RAGAVAN
Naalu page, da. Moonu mani neram paper-la naalu page, rendai mudhal irubadhu nimishathuleye mudichitten.

All of it true. The hall laughs, because he has said it as a boast, and a boast is how you say a thing so that nobody checks it.

The classmate comes back into the hall for the water bottle he left on his desk.

THE CLASSMATE
Kalyanam Sunday mudinjidichu. Paravaalla, naan appaavodhu podutten.

It takes Ragavan a second to place it. The jacket. Four weeks ago. By then the classmate has gone.

Anbu comes up the aisle behind him with his own booklet already handed in.

ANBU
Question four.

RAGAVAN
Hall pooravum suthidichu.

ANBU
Unkitta vandhudha?

RAGAVAN
Ennkitta irundhu dhaan kelambichu.

ANBU
Adhu adha theriyaradhu kidaiyadhu.

Ragavan puts an arm round him and takes him out into the corridor with the rest of them, laughing.

At the front of the empty hall, a stack of sixty booklets, squared off, with one string tie hanging out of it.

CUT TO:

INT. COLLEGE CORRIDOR - ARREARS BOARD - DAY

The same corridor. The same tubes. The same glass.

Twenty-five students in front of the board, and not one of them is looking at the arrears sheet.

They are at the other end of the glass, where a second sheet has gone up: the names cleared to sit the November drive.

RAGAVAN comes along the corridor at his own speed, with three people saying the new name at him on the way.

He reaches the crowd and the crowd does not open for him, because it is busy.

He reads the drive list from the outside of it, over a shoulder, in one pass.

His name is not on it. He did not expect it to be. He checks twice anyway.

Then he goes to the other end of the glass, where there is nobody.

The arrears sheet has been retyped. Fresh paper. The clerk's margins.

Insert: his name, and after it, on one line, eleven subject codes.

Somebody in the office has tidied the second line up into the first.

Four days ago it was ten, with one carried over to where nobody reads.

It is eleven now, and it is all on one line, and it is in order.

He raises his hand to the glass the way he did with forty people behind him. Flat. Ready to tap.

He does not tap it.

He counts along the line with one finger instead, touching the glass over each code, and says none of it.

At the sixth he stops and goes back to the beginning, because he has lost the count, which did not happen when there was an audience.

He starts again.

Behind him the crowd laughs at something on the drive list and moves off down the corridor, and the corridor is his.

He finishes the count.

RAGAVAN
Pathinonnu.

Said to nobody, in an empty corridor, at the same volume he used for the joke on Tuesday.

The tube above the board is failing at one end, and has been failing for three years.

In the glass, over the list, his own reflection, and behind that the window at the far end of the corridor.

He puts his palm flat on the glass, over his own name.

The list reads perfectly well without it. Two hundred names, four columns, in alphabetical order.

He takes the hand away. The print of it stays on the glass for a moment and then goes.

A clerk comes past with a key on a string, checks that the glass is locked, and goes on without reading either sheet.

The dean's slip is in Ragavan's shirt pocket, folded down to the size of a stamp.

He takes it out, looks at the date on it, and puts it back in the same fold.

Down the corridor, the drive list, with twenty-five students worth of fingerprints on the glass in front of it.

In front of his own sheet, one.

He straightens his collar, which there is nobody here to see straightened.

Then he goes, walking the way he always walks, and he is the only one in the corridor to see it.

Behind him the board. The glass. Eleven codes in the clerk's margins, in order, with ninety days of term left.

CUT TO:

INT. MEN'S HOSTEL ROOM - NIGHT

Two cots. One window with a grille. A table fan turning its head slowly, like it is looking for somebody who left.

A suitcase lies open on the floor, half filled. Not packed. Loaded, the way you load a bag you intend to carry past a gate.

RAGAVAN sits on the edge of his cot with a mirror propped against the wall between his knees. A pair of clippers in his right hand, not plugged in.

ANBU is at the table with his notebook open. He has been on the same page a while.

ANBU
Pathinonnu.

Ragavan reaches behind him and pushes the plug into the socket. The tube light dips and comes back.

ANBU (CONT'D)
Pathinonnu-nu sonnen.

RAGAVAN
Mudhal thadavaye kekkum da.

ANBU
Apparam badhil sollu.

RAGAVAN
Enna badhil sollanum? Pathinonnu?

The clippers come on. A flat industrial note, louder than the fan.

He puts them to the side of his head and takes a strip off, front to back, in one run. It is not a careful run.

ANBU
Apdi illa—

Hair on the floor tiles. A pale band of scalp where the strip was. Anbu stops talking.

ANBU (CONT'D)
Seri.

RAGAVAN
Kannadiya pidi.

Anbu does not get up. Then he gets up, crosses, and holds the mirror at the angle Ragavan's chin asks for.

Ragavan works. Anbu reads the page from memory, because he is not looking at it.

ANBU
Second year la moonu. Third year la naalu. Indha year la naalu baaki.

RAGAVAN
Ulla romba neat-a vechirukke.

ANBU
Yaaravadhu vechaaganum.

The clippers snag. Ragavan pulls them free and a patch comes away shorter than the rest, right above his ear.

Anbu looks at it in the mirror. Ragavan looks at it in the mirror. Neither of them says anything for four seconds.

ANBU
Indha pakkam jaasti poyiduchu.

RAGAVAN
Apo andha pakkamum jaasti pannu.

He hands the clippers over. Anbu sets down the mirror, stands behind him and starts to even it out. Two hands, careful, the way you do a thing for a friend.

ANBU
Enga poore?

RAGAVAN
Veliya.

ANBU
Suitcase odanaya?

RAGAVAN
Chinna suitcase dhaan.

Anbu switches the clippers off. The fan is the only sound again.

Ragavan stands. He takes the mirror off the table and holds it up himself, and for the first time in the scene he stops moving.

The face in it is harder than the one that sat down. Nothing has been added. Things have been taken away.

He crouches at the suitcase and takes out a shirt — full sleeves, stiff from the shop fold. He puts it on over the vest and does the buttons from the bottom up.

ANBU
Adhu yaaru shirt?

RAGAVAN
Ennoda.

ANBU
Eppo irundhu.

RAGAVAN
Ippo irundhu.

He cuffs the sleeves down over his wrists. Shuts the suitcase. The catches take two tries.

On the inside of the room door, a paper strip the warden's office typed and taped up in first year. Two names on it. ANBU. RAGAVAN.

Ragavan picks a marker off the table, uncaps it with his teeth, and puts one flat line through his own name.

Above the line he writes six letters in capitals. It takes him two seconds. He does not stand back to look at it.

ANBU
Adhu quad la unna paathu kathuravanga da. Adhu oru peru illa.

RAGAVAN
Ippo adhu dhaan.

He caps the marker and puts it back on the table, in the place it was.

ANBU
Ragavan.

Ragavan lifts the suitcase. At the door he turns, and he is entirely pleasant about it.

RAGAVAN
Keela porappo poottitu po.

The door closes. Anbu stands in the middle of the room with the clippers still in his hand.

He sits. He opens the notebook, looks at the figure at the bottom of the page, and does not change it.

Hair on the tiles. The fan turns away from him.

EXT. CERTIFICATE PRINT LANE, PARRYS CORNER - DAY

A lane the width of two hand carts, roofed in tarpaulin and cable. The buildings on either side were painted the same year and have not been painted since.

Thirty shops, all in one trade. Printing. The boards above them list it out: wedding cards, bill books, visiting cards, rubber stamps, ID cards, certificates.

RAGAVAN comes down the lane in the full-sleeved shirt, sleeves buttoned at the wrist. Nobody looks at him. There is no reason to.

He stops at the fourth because there is nobody in it.

INSERT — the glass counter top. Under the glass, samples laid out in rows, fading at the edges.

A marriage invitation. A tenth standard mark sheet. A shop licence. A degree certificate, somebody else's name on it, the ink gone brown.

All of them the same size. All of them under the same glass.

Behind the counter a man in his fifties is eating from a steel tiffin box with one hand and working a keyboard with the other.

A boy of about fourteen squats by the laminating machine, feeding it sheets and catching them on the far side.

Ragavan waits. The man finishes a mouthful. Puts the lid on the box. Wipes his hand on a cloth kept there for it.

A woman ahead of Ragavan collects four laminated cards in a rubber band. She counts them. She pays. She leaves.

That takes about forty seconds and is the whole transaction.

The man does not ask what he wants. He turns a ring binder around on the counter and pushes it across.

INSERT — the binder. Plastic sleeves. In each sleeve a specimen, and under it a number written in ballpoint. The numbers are prices.

Degrees are on the fourth page. They are after the mark sheets and before the experience letters.

The man holds up a folder of paper samples instead — eight blank squares on a ring, like a paint chart.

INSERT — a thumb and forefinger take one square, rub it, let it go. Take the next one. The second square is heavier and has a faint grain in it.

RAGAVAN
Thick-aana adhu.

The man writes something on a slip. He turns the monitor on its swivel so the counter can see it.

On screen, a template. Boxes where the words go. The cursor sits in the first box, blinking.

Ragavan says his name. He says it the way you say it at a bank counter, flat, with the spelling after it.

The man types. He does not ask for a spelling twice and he does not ask anything else.

INSERT — the screen. The name fills the box. Underneath it the template's own grey placeholder words sit waiting: degree, branch, class, month, year.

Ragavan gives him a year. It is one year ago.

A printer under the counter starts without being told to. It is an ordinary office printer on an ordinary office table.

INSERT — the sheet comes out face down, warm, and the man picks it up by two corners the way anybody picks up anything.

He holds it under the tube light for a second. Not to admire it. To see whether the printer has streaked.

It has not. He puts it on the counter.

INSERT — the certificate, face up, square to frame. One sheet. Black text, two lines of it in a larger face, a blank disc at the foot where a seal goes.

It does not look clever. It does not look convincing. It looks like a sheet of paper from a shop that prints sheets of paper.

The man pulls a cast-iron press to the edge of the counter, slides the sheet under it, lays a square of gold foil over the blank disc and pulls the lever with his whole shoulder.

A click. He lifts the lever. The foil peels off and goes in the bin and there is a seal where the disc was.

He takes a rubber stamp from a wooden block of forty rubber stamps, breathes on it, and prints it in the bottom left corner without measuring.

The whole operation has taken less time than the woman's four laminated cards.

RAGAVAN
Lamination vendam.

The man shrugs and does not argue. Lamination is extra and the shrug is about the money, not about the paper.

He reaches under the counter for a brown envelope off a stack of a hundred identical brown envelopes, and slides the sheet in.

INSERT — a calculator turned around on the glass. A three-figure number.

Ragavan counts notes out of his shirt pocket. He is four short. He checks the other pocket and finds them.

The man puts the money in a tin, puts the tin back, and goes back to the tiffin box.

The envelope stays on the counter between them for a moment because nobody has picked it up.

Ragavan picks it up.

Out in the lane he gets eight or nine steps and stops beside a cart, and opens the envelope with one finger, there in the traffic, which is the only risk he takes all day.

INSERT — his own name on a line, in a face designed by somebody who has never met him, under a gold circle the size of a two rupee coin.

His face does not do anything. He is not frightened of it and he is not proud of it. He is checking the spelling.

The spelling is correct.

He folds the flap down, tucks the envelope under his arm like a man carrying an electricity bill home, and goes on up the lane.

Behind him the boy feeds the next sheet into the laminator, and the machine takes it, and lets it out the other side.

INT. CORPORATE OFFICE — HR ROOM - DAY

A room with no windows and no shadows in it. Two desks, one in use. A wall chart about fire exits that has never been read by anybody.

Through the open door, the corridor: ten candidates on plastic chairs, each holding a folder thick enough to need a rubber band.

RAGAVAN sits across the desk with a brown envelope on his knee. It is the only thing he has brought.

The HR MANAGER works a keyboard with the screen turned away from him. She has done this nine times today.

HR MANAGER
Originals kudunga.

Ragavan slides the envelope across. She shakes the sheet out of it, holds it at arm's length, and puts it face down on the glass of the copier behind her without turning her head.

The copier light goes across. She takes the copy, staples it to a form, and hands the original back.

The whole examination has lasted four seconds and was about whether the sheet would fit on the glass.

HR MANAGER (CONT'D)
Attested-a?

RAGAVAN
Adhu ippo venuma, illa joining la venuma?

HR MANAGER
Joining.

RAGAVAN
Apo joining la.

She makes a mark on the form. It is a tick. She has ticked a box that says the question was asked.

HR MANAGER
Year of passing.

He gives her a year. It is last year. She types it without repeating it back.

HR MANAGER (CONT'D)
Blood group.

RAGAVAN
B positive.

HR MANAGER
Emergency contact. Peru-um relation-um.

A small stop. The first one in the scene, and she does not notice it because she is looking at the screen.

RAGAVAN
Appa.

HR MANAGER
Number.

He gives it from memory. She types that too.

HR MANAGER (CONT'D)
Previous employer, and notice period enna?

RAGAVAN
First job.

Now she looks up. Not suspicious. Mildly inconvenienced, the way a form is inconvenienced.

HR MANAGER
Irubathi aaru vayasula?

RAGAVAN
Adhukku oru box irukka?

HR MANAGER
Ellaathukkum oru box irukku.

RAGAVAN
Apo enna adhula podunga ma'am.

She almost smiles. She puts him in it. Three keystrokes, and a man who has never worked anywhere has worked here since nine o'clock this morning.

She rolls her chair two feet to the ID card printer on the side table and presses the button on it.

The printer takes a blank card in, makes a sound like a cough, and stops. A red light comes on.

She presses the button again. Same cough. Same light.

She picks up the desk phone, dials four digits, lets it ring seven times and puts it down.

HR MANAGER
Avar naalu manikku varuvaar. Card Thursday ready aagidum.

RAGAVAN
Naan paarattuma?

She moves her hand across the table — not permission, exactly. Absence of objection.

Ragavan gets up, crouches to the machine's level, and finds the catch on the front panel with his thumb before he has looked for it.

INSERT — the panel swings down. Inside, a ribbon on two spindles, and a blank card jammed sideways under it with one corner creased.

He lifts the left spindle out of its seat, slides the card free, and runs the slack ribbon back on with his finger until it sits flat.

He seats the spindle. Closes the panel. Presses the same button she pressed twice.

The printer takes a card, holds it, and starts to lay colour down in strips.

The HR Manager watches the card come out. Then she looks at him, properly, for the first time since he sat down.

HR MANAGER
Idha munnadiye pannirukkinga.

RAGAVAN
Bill printer la irukkura same ribbon dhaan. Enga veettu keezha kadaila onnu irukku.

That is the first entirely true sentence he has said in this room, and it is the one that gets him looked at.

She takes the card out, checks the photograph against his face, and threads it onto a blue lanyard.

HR MANAGER
Fourth floor. Nine o'clock. Card tholedhuchunna, irunooru rubaa, oru vaaram.

RAGAVAN
Card-a naan tholeka maaten.

She is already pulling the next file across. The copy of his certificate goes into it, stapled, and the file goes into a tray with forty other files.

The original is in his hand. Nobody in this building will ever ask to see it again.

Ragavan puts the lanyard over his head on the way out and walks down the corridor past the ten candidates with their folders.

Every one of them looks up at the card on his chest. He does not look back at any of them.

INT. CORPORATE OFFICE — OPEN FLOOR - DAY

Fifty five workstations in rows under a ceiling of flat panel light. No windows on this side. No shadows anywhere.

One aisle runs the length of it. Everything on the floor happens on either side of that aisle.

RAGAVAN comes down it behind the PROJECT LEAD, who walks and talks at the same speed and does not turn around to check.

PROJECT LEAD
Bank. Four regions. 2004 system la irukkanga, March kulla adhula irundhu move pannanum.

RAGAVAN
Move pannitu enga kondu poreenga?

PROJECT LEAD
Adhu rendaavadhu kelvi. Ellarum mudhalla kekkuranga.

He stops at a desk with a dead monitor on it and a chair that somebody has already adjusted for somebody else.

PROJECT LEAD (CONT'D)
Ungaloda.

A laptop. A yellow sticky note on the lid with a password on it in ballpoint, and under the password, the word TEMP, underlined twice.

RAGAVAN
Enakku login?

PROJECT LEAD
Thursday.

At the next desk, PALLAVI has a headset on one ear and two windows open and is typing into one of them while listening to the other.

She lifts a hand without looking away from the screen. It is a greeting and an instruction to wait, in one movement.

PROJECT LEAD (CONT'D)
Migration-e start aagardhukku munnadiye avanga idhula irukkanga. Edhu venaalum rendu thadava kelunga.

RAGAVAN
Yen rendu thadava?

PROJECT LEAD
Mudhal thadava, neenge padichukkonga-nu solluvanga.

The Project Lead is gone up the aisle before the sentence has finished landing.

Ragavan sits. He adjusts the chair back to his own height and the gas lift drops him eight inches. He adjusts it again.

He opens the laptop. He types the password off the sticky note, then peels the note off the lid, folds it in half and puts it in his pocket.

On the screen: a shared drive with four hundred folders in it and no instructions about any of them.

Around him the floor goes on with its day. Somebody's phone rings for a long time at an empty desk.

Pallavi takes the headset off and turns, and her first look at him is the look you give a chair that has been moved.

PALLAVI
New-a?

RAGAVAN
Onbadhu la irundhu.

PALLAVI
Deck Shared-la irukku, Onboarding keezha. Forty slides. Padinga, ulla enna-nu kekkadhinga.

RAGAVAN
Deck edhula irundhu panninga, adha kudukka mudiyuma?

She stops. Not impressed yet. Interested, which is a smaller thing and harder to get.

PALLAVI
Adhaavadhu?

RAGAVAN
Data. Eleven o'clock ku ellarum edha pathi kathureengalo adhu.

A beat. She turns her second monitor forty degrees so it faces into the gap between the desks.

INSERT — a log file, black on white, scrolling. Thousands of lines of it. At intervals, a red line.

PALLAVI
Nightly run. Ezhu naal la naalu naal clean-a mudiyudhu. Edha naalu-nu yaaralum solla mudiyala.

RAGAVAN
Eppo irundhu naalu-a irukku?

PALLAVI
Onbadhu vaaram.

Ragavan pulls his chair across the gap and into her bay without being invited. She lets it happen.

He does not scroll down. He takes the scroll bar and drags it to the very bottom, and reads upward.

PALLAVI (CONT'D)
Error mela dhaan irukku.

RAGAVAN
Error mela irukku. Reason keezha irukku.

He reads. It takes him a while, and the scene does not help him by cutting away.

On the other side of the aisle two men argue about a conference room booking. Somebody brings a tray of tea through and does not stop at either desk.

Ragavan puts one finger on the screen, which nobody who works in an office does.

RAGAVAN (CONT'D)
Idhu 02:00 ku file close pannudhu.

PALLAVI
Appadi dhaan panna vendum.

RAGAVAN
Branch regions 01:30 ku anuppudhu. Naalum.

PALLAVI
Aama.

RAGAVAN
Moonu anuppudhu. Onnu oru mani late-a, 02:30 ku anuppudhu, appo unga job veetukku poiduchu.

Pallavi does not say anything. She takes the mouse back off him, scrolls, stops, and reads the same four lines twice.

INSERT — the timestamp column. Three entries at 01:28, 01:29, 01:31. The fourth, far below, at 02:34.

She sits back. She looks down the floor at the whiteboard where nine weeks of theories are written in four colours.

PALLAVI
Keezha irundhu padikka yaaru sonnaa?

RAGAVAN
Yaarum illa. Nadandha ellaathoda list adhu. Kadaisiya nadandhadhula edhukku start pannanum?

She looks at him for a second longer than she means to. Then she picks up the headset.

PALLAVI
Ippo yaarkittayum sollaadheenga. Vendumne mudhalla break pannanum.

RAGAVAN
Inniki 01:45 ku break pannunga, fail aagum. Rendu manikku pannunga, aagaadhu.

She writes that on the back of her hand, which is not where anybody is supposed to write anything.

The Project Lead goes past up the aisle with a cup in each hand and does not stop.

Ragavan rolls his chair back into his own bay. He opens the folder of four hundred folders again and starts at the one at the bottom.

INT. CORPORATE OFFICE — OPEN FLOOR - DAY

Six months of the same light. The whiteboard at the head of the aisle has been wiped and rewritten so many times it has gone grey and will not come clean.

On a wall screen above it, a row of green ticks, one for each night. They go back further than the screen is wide.

By the lift there is a notice board. Printed sheet, behind glass, four drawing pins holding it flat at the corners.

Fifteen or twenty people are standing in front of it, which is more than stand in front of anything else in this building.

RAGAVAN comes out of the lift and does not go to it. He goes to his desk, puts his bag down, and then goes to it.

INSERT — through glass, a list of names under a heading about the quarter. Names, then a band, then a date.

He reads it the way a man reads a board behind glass. Finger not quite touching. Lips not quite moving.

He finds his name. He does not look at it. He counts the names above it instead, and there are four, and he stops counting.

Behind the glass the paper has gone slightly wavy at one corner with the air conditioning, the way the paper on the other board used to go.

Somebody behind him says well done without stopping walking. He says thanks to a back.

The PROJECT LEAD arrives at his shoulder with a cup and stands looking at the board as though he has not read it forty times already.

PROJECT LEAD
Mudhal thedhi irundhu effective.

RAGAVAN
Indha maasam mudhal thedhiya, illa adhutha maasama?

PROJECT LEAD
Paarunga, adhaan unga peru board la irukku.

He walks. Ragavan goes with him, down the aisle, past forty desks that all look up for exactly as long as it takes them to look back down.

PROJECT LEAD (CONT'D)
Monday la irundhu client calls neenga dhaan.

RAGAVAN
Edha client?

PROJECT LEAD
Ellaarum.

They stop at the end of the row, by the aisle, where there is a desk with nothing on it and a chair nobody has sat in.

PROJECT LEAD (CONT'D)
Idhu ungaloda. Lunch kku munnadi saamaan-a maathunga, housekeeping rendu manikku cables paarpaanga.

The move is eight feet. It takes four trips, because a monitor needs two hands and nothing else does.

A keyboard. A cable with a knot in it he cannot undo and carries knotted. A plant somebody gave him that he has kept alive out of what looks like spite.

Two desks away a man watches the whole operation with open resentment and says nothing at all.

The old desk stands empty behind him with four clean rectangles on it where things used to be, and the resentful man has already moved his chair six inches toward it.

On the fourth trip Ragavan finds a small wooden nameplate on the new desk, face down, left there by somebody from stores.

INSERT — he turns it over. His name, routed into the wood and filled with white paint. There is one letter too many in it.

He looks at it for a while. The Project Lead, going past again, sees him looking.

PROJECT LEAD
Spelling thappa irukku.

RAGAVAN
Oru letter dhaane.

PROJECT LEAD
Thirumba pannitu tharen. Oru vaaram aagum.

RAGAVAN
Vendam.

He stands it up at the front edge of the desk, square to the aisle, where everybody who walks past will read it.

He rubs the paint with his thumb and a little of the white comes off on his thumb, and he wipes that on his trousers.

PROJECT LEAD
One thing. Band change aagardhukku munnadi HR kku file la attested copies venum.

Ragavan is still arranging the nameplate. He does not stop arranging the nameplate.

RAGAVAN
Edhoda copies?

PROJECT LEAD
Degree. Ellarukkum adhe dhaan. Idhu oru form, investigation illa.

RAGAVAN
Kondu varen.

PROJECT LEAD
Avasaram illa. Quarter end kkulla.

The Project Lead goes. The floor goes on. Somewhere behind the rows, a printer starts up and runs for a long time.

Ragavan sits down in the new chair. From here he can see the whole aisle, which is the only thing this desk has that the other one did not.

He looks at the nameplate with the extra letter in it, standing square to everybody.

Then he pulls the keyboard across, and starts work, and is good at it.

INT. RAGAVAN'S HOUSE, VILLIVAKKAM - NIGHT

One room that is the hall, the dining room and the place the almirah stands. A tube light. A fan that ticks once every turn.

Three steel plates on the table. Rice, one curry, a fried thing on the side of each plate because there is an occasion.

The occasion is lying in the middle of the table where no paper should ever lie. A printed letter, out of its envelope, with a half moon of water on one corner.

RAGAVAN'S FATHER holds it at arm's length with his glasses pushed up on his forehead, which is how he has read everything for nine years.

RAGAVAN eats. RAGAVAN'S MOTHER stands at the end of the table with the vessel, not sitting, because she will sit when everybody has had seconds.

RAGAVAN'S FATHER
Edha company idhu?

RAGAVAN
Oru firm. Bank kku velai senjuduvaanga.

RAGAVAN'S FATHER
Bank-aa, illa bank kku velaiya?

RAGAVAN
Bank kku. Bank aale adha panna mudiyadhu, adhanaala kaasu tharudhu.

His father turns the letter over to see whether there is anything on the back. There is nothing on the back.

RAGAVAN'S MOTHER
Saappadu kudupaangala?

RAGAVAN
Canteen irukku.

RAGAVAN'S MOTHER
Free-ya, illa kaasu kudukkanuma?

RAGAVAN
Subsidy irukku.

She considers the word, decides it is on her side, and puts another spoon of rice on his plate without being asked.

The father sets the letter down and pulls his glasses onto his nose, which means he is finished reading and about to start talking.

RAGAVAN'S FATHER
Seri. Engineering mudinjiduchu.

It is not a question and it does not want an answer. Ragavan puts a piece of the fried thing in his mouth so that his mouth is busy.

RAGAVAN'S FATHER (CONT'D)
Ippo masters. Veliye, foreign la. Rendu varusham. Appo unakku sondha kaasu irukkum, naan yaarkittayum kai neetta koodaadhu.

RAGAVAN
Rendu varusham indha veetta yaaru paathukkuvaanga?

RAGAVAN'S FATHER
Veedu moonaavadhu vishayam. Adhukku munnadi illa.

He points his chin at the ceiling. Everybody at the table looks up, out of long habit.

INSERT — the ceiling, and where it stops. Through the open stair gap, six iron rods stand out of the roof slab against the night sky, gone the colour of rain, waiting for a first floor.

RAGAVAN'S FATHER (CONT'D)
Adhu oru room aagura varaikkum kalyaana pechu illa. Appo sonnen, ippovum sollren.

RAGAVAN
Neenga sonnadhu enakku theriyum.

A silence with three people in it and only the fan working.

She picks the letter up off the table, because paper during food has been annoying her since it arrived, and opens the middle drawer of the almirah.

INSERT — the drawer. Ration papers, a torch, a key with no label. And a flat cardboard box, dark red, with the corners gone soft.

She slides the box six inches to the left to make space, and lays the offer letter flat beside it. Two pieces of paper, in one drawer, at the same depth.

She does not open the box. She shuts the drawer.

Ragavan has watched the whole thing from the table with his hand stopped halfway to his plate.

On the wall above the almirah, a framed photograph: a boy of seventeen on a stage, and two people at the back of a hall, out of focus.

The father gets up, and on his way past he puts one finger on the corner of the frame and straightens it a quarter inch, which he does every night.

He goes. The mother sits down at last, at the corner of the table, and eats from the vessel.

RAGAVAN'S MOTHER
Anga enna panre? Unmaiyaa.

Ragavan thinks about it properly, which he has not done for anybody else.

RAGAVAN
Naalu office raathiri avanga velaiya anuppum. Onnu late-a anuppum. Edhu-nu naan kandupidichen.

RAGAVAN'S MOTHER
Adhukku kaasu tharaangala?

RAGAVAN
Adhukku kaasu tharaanga.

She nods, satisfied, and goes on eating. Every word he has said to her tonight has been true.

INT. CORPORATE OFFICE — GLASS MEETING ROOM - DAY

A box of glass on three sides. One long table, dead centre. Six chairs one side, three the other, and the same number of water glasses on each.

Six CLIENTS take the six. They are all wearing the same colour and two of them have not taken the caps off their pens.

On the near side, the PROJECT LEAD in the middle chair, PALLAVI on his left with a laptop, RAGAVAN on his right with nothing in front of him but a glass of water.

Beyond the glass, the floor. Twenty people at their desks, backs to the room, doing their day.

The projector throws a title slide on the end wall. It is the right title and it is the wrong version, because the date on it is six weeks old.

Pallavi sees the date. She looks at the Project Lead. The Project Lead has already started talking.

PROJECT LEAD
Thank you all for coming in. Slide two la naama enga irukkom-nu theriyum.

Slide two is an architecture diagram with nineteen boxes on it. He reads the boxes out in order.

By the fourth box, one of the clients has turned his phone face up on the table. By the seventh, two of them are looking at it.

Pallavi types something and slides the laptop two inches toward the Project Lead. He does not look down at it.

The man at the far end of the client side puts his hand flat on the table, which in a room like this is the same as standing up.

He asks why, nineteen months in, the four regional figures his bank publishes on a Monday have never once added up to the figure this company sends him on the Sunday night.

He says he has asked it twice before, in this room, at this table.

A silence of the kind that has a cost attached to it.

PROJECT LEAD
We have that under analysis. Pallavi, neenga—

Pallavi does not take it. She turns her head, three quarters of an inch, toward the chair on the other side of the Project Lead.

Ragavan is already standing up.

He walks to the end wall and switches the projector off at the wall, which no one in the history of this room has ever done.

The slide goes. The room gets its own light back, and everybody's eyes come up off the table because there is nothing else to look at.

He takes a marker out of the tray and draws on the inside of the glass wall. Four squares in a row. Nothing else.

RAGAVAN
Unga naalu regions. Sir, indha naalula edha pathi neenga worry panreenga?

The man at the end says none of them. He says that is the point. All four report the same way.

RAGAVAN (CONT'D)
Ellaarum same way la report pannuranga. Aana same time la illa.

He writes a time under each square. Three of them are the same time. The fourth is an hour later.

Then he draws a line down the glass between the third square and the fourth, and writes one more figure at the top of the line, and underlines it.

RAGAVAN (CONT'D)
Namma job rendu manikku file-a close pannudhu. Unga naalula onnu arai manikkum ezhudhindu irukku.

Nobody says anything. Then the man at the end of the table takes the cap off his pen.

INSERT — his notebook. He writes a time. Under it, a word, and the word is the name of one region.

The woman beside him asks how long this has been true, and Ragavan says since the fourth region moved its evening batch back an hour in March and told nobody.

She asks how he knows and he says it is in the log, at the bottom, and the room has been reading the logs from the top.

Somebody laughs — a short laugh, with relief in it. The Project Lead laughs a beat after everybody else.

For four minutes the glass wall is the meeting. Ragavan answers nine questions and does not get one of them wrong.

Pallavi has stopped typing. She is sitting back with her hands off the keyboard, watching him work, and what is on her face is not admiration. It is arithmetic.

Then the easy part of the meeting arrives, the way it always does, in the last two minutes when the hard thing is settled.

The man at the end of the table caps his pen, nods at the glass, and asks Ragavan where he studied.

The room is at its most relaxed it has been since it sat down. The question is small talk. It is the only question in the room that matters.

RAGAVAN
Inga dhaan sir. City la.

He gives the name of the college. He gives it in the same voice he gave the timestamps in, and he does not hurry the sentence.

The man says he has a cousin who took his degree there, two or three years back, and asks whether Ragavan knew him.

RAGAVAN (CONT'D)
Avaru branch enna?

The man does not remember his own cousin's branch. He laughs at himself about it, and the woman beside him laughs, and the subject is finished.

Four seconds. That is the whole audit, and it was carried out by a man who could not remember a branch.

Chairs go back. Hands get shaken across the table in the wrong order, as they always are.

The man at the end holds on to Ragavan's hand half a second longer and says he wants him on the Sunday call.

The clients file out. Beyond the glass, people at the desks turn round to watch six men in one colour walk the length of the aisle.

The Project Lead gathers the clicker and the carafe and is extremely pleased with the room in general.

PROJECT LEAD
That went well. Naan oru note anuppren.

RAGAVAN
Avanga perayum podunga. Prove panna rendu manikku kaal kuraiya avanga vendumne break panninanga.

PROJECT LEAD
Rendu peru.

He goes. Pallavi stays in her chair with the laptop shut, and Ragavan starts rubbing the four squares off the glass with the side of his hand.

PALLAVI
Oru single slide koodaama adha panninga.

RAGAVAN
Slide la date thappa irundhadhu.

PALLAVI
Ippo ovvoru thadavaiyum unga pera dhaan kepaanga. Theriyum la.

Ragavan goes on cleaning the glass. The marker does not come off completely and leaves four grey ghosts where the squares were.

RAGAVAN
Apo Sunday naan varanum.

Through the glass, twenty people at their desks, none of them looking in.

EXT. BESANT NAGAR BEACH ROAD - DUSK

The light going down behind the buildings on the land side, so the sea is the dark half and the road is the bright one.

Walkers on the pavement in both directions. Two vendors with glass boxes on stands and paper cones stacked in a tower beside each.

RAGAVAN'S hatchback is parked with two wheels on the kerb, like every other car on this stretch.

RAGAVAN and PALLAVI walk north, on the sea side, not touching. They have been talking about the Sunday call for twenty minutes.

PALLAVI
Reconciliation second floor irubathi rendukkulla venumaam.

RAGAVAN

Avangalukku irubathi onbadhu kidaikkum, adhukke santhoshapaduvaanga.

PALLAVI
Adha avangakitta sollave mudiyadhu.

RAGAVAN
Naan adha sollave maaten. Irubathi ettu-nu solluven.

She laughs once, down her nose, and walks four steps without saying anything, which is how she changes the subject.

PALLAVI
Idhu pakka pocket la enna?

Ragavan keeps walking at exactly the same speed, which is the only thing that gives him away.

RAGAVAN
Saavi.

PALLAVI
Saavi valadhu pakkam irukku. Lift la irundhu andha pocket mela kai vechindey irukke.

He stops walking. She goes two paces past him before she notices, and then she turns round on the pavement with the sea behind her.

He gets the box out. It is small, and it is not a good box — it is the box the shop gives you, with the shop's name rubbed off the lid.

He has a dozen sentences prepared and he can feel every one of them leaving.

RAGAVAN
Idhukku munnadi onnu sollanum-nu vechirundhen.

PALLAVI
Sollu.

RAGAVAN
Ellaathaiyum marandhuten.

PALLAVI
Nalladhu. Nedusa irundhirukkum.

A vendor arrives beside them with a cone in each hand, because a man standing still on this road holding a box is a customer.

Ragavan takes both cones without looking at them, because his hands were full and now they are fuller.

Pallavi takes the box off him so that he can pay. She holds it while he counts coins. Nobody has opened it yet.

The vendor goes. They are left with two paper cones of hot sundal and a ring box, held by the wrong people.

PALLAVI
Mudhalla oru vishayam kekkattuma.

RAGAVAN
Kelu.

PALLAVI
Un pathi naan appuram kandupidikka edhaavadhu irukka?

She is not being tender. She asks it the way she asks whether a file has been checked in — because she intends to use the answer.

The sea behind her. The road traffic going both ways. He has about three seconds of other people's noise to decide in.

And for a moment the whole of it is right there in his mouth: the shop, the brown envelope, the four seconds on the copier glass.

A scooter goes past close with two children on it and the horn takes the three seconds away.

When it is quiet again his face has changed back. It is the face from the glass meeting room, and it is pleasant, and it is quick.

RAGAVAN
Idhula naan theriyaradhuvida mosam.

PALLAVI
Adhu naan appuram kandupidikkiradhu illa. Adhu inniki.

She takes it. She has no reason on earth not to take it, and she is a person who checks everything, and this is the one she does not check.

She opens the box herself. Looks in. Looks up.

PALLAVI (CONT'D)
Idhu nee guess panna size-aa, illa alandha size-aa?

RAGAVAN
Guess panninen.

She puts it on. It is loose by about one size. She closes her hand into a fist and keeps it closed, which solves it.

PALLAVI
Unga appa. Mela floor innum kattave illa.

RAGAVAN
Illa.

PALLAVI
Edhuvum mudivaagardhukku munnadi adha katti mudikkanum-nu kepaaru.

RAGAVAN
Appadi andha order la dhaan avar kepaaru, aama.

PALLAVI
Apo naama kattalaam. Tiles podaama irundha pathinettu maasam.

She has already done the sum. She did it before she came out tonight, which means she knew about the pocket since Tuesday.

They start walking again, north, in the last of it. She has one fist shut and one paper cone, and she is eating out of it with her thumb.

Ragavan walks beside her and does not eat anything at all.

EXT. ENGINEERING COLLEGE — QUAD - DAY

The quad has not changed. The same four blocks round the same dry grass, the same covered walk down one side with the same chipped pillars.

Eighty students cross it in the ten minutes between hours. None of them is the batch that was here before.

A folding table has been set up under the walk with a banner taped to the front of it. Campus drive. Two chairs behind it and one of them is RAGAVAN'S.

He is not sitting in it. He is standing in front of the table with a group of six around him, because that is where he has always been happiest.

INSERT — clipped to his shirt pocket, a stiff plastic visitor badge with the day's date hand written on it in marker.

A student asks him something and he answers it without any of the sentences the company printed for him.

RAGAVAN
Marks-a mela podaadhinga. Neenga sari panna vishayathai mela podunga. Marks rendaavadhu page.

The six write that down, all of them, at the same time, which is a thing that happens to him now.

He is enjoying himself. He is enjoying himself enough that he does not look down the covered walk for ten seconds longer than he should.

At the far end of the walk, THE DEAN has stopped.

He is holding a register against his chest with both hands. He is not hurrying. He has not raised a hand, or called out, or done anything at all.

He is just standing in the walk looking down it, the way a man looks at a figure that does not reconcile.

Ragavan sees him. The six are still writing.

The Dean comes down the walk. It takes him about nine seconds and the scene gives him all nine of them.

The students feel the temperature change before they know why, and dissolve sideways into the quad without anybody telling them to.

THE DEAN
Ragavan.

Not loud. Not unkind. The first time in three years anybody has used that name on this quad.

RAGAVAN
Sir. Nalla irukkeenga sir.

THE DEAN
Neengal oru recruitment table-il.

RAGAVAN
Campus theriyum-nu anuppi vechaanga. Office la irundhu arai naal, sir, adhu mattum dhaan.

The Dean's eyes go to the badge on his pocket and stay there for two seconds, reading it. He does not touch it.

THE DEAN
Ungalai hiring pakkam vaithirukkiraargal.

RAGAVAN
Pesaradhu mattum. Papers-a vera yaaro paarthukkuvaanga.

It is a joke. It is the kind of joke that lands in a corridor at the office and goes nowhere at all here.

THE DEAN
Aaraam semester-il vilaginirgal.

RAGAVAN
Aaraam semester la varadhu nirutinen. Rendum onnu illa.

THE DEAN
Illai. Onnu illai.

That is the whole of it. He does not push. There is nothing in his face to push back against, which is the problem.

Behind them a bell goes and the quad fills and empties again, and the two of them stand in it like two posts.

THE DEAN
En office. Naalai, pathu mani.

RAGAVAN
Sunday call ku prepare pannanum sir, mudiyuma-nu theriyala—

THE DEAN
Pathu mani.

He goes back up the covered walk with the register against his chest, at the same speed he came down it.

Ragavan stands by the folding table. After a while he sits down in the chair behind it, which he had not done all morning.

The six students come back, one at a time, with their notebooks still open and their questions ready.

INT. DEAN'S OFFICE - DAY

A desk with nothing personal on it. A lamp with a green glass shade, switched on although the window is open and it is ten in the morning.

On the wall, a calendar. Twelve months on one sheet. Nothing written on it anywhere except the term dates, which are printed.

THE DEAN is reading a file when RAGAVAN comes in. He goes on reading it for a while after Ragavan has come in.

The file is thin. That is the first thing about it. Six years of a man and it does not fill a folder.

THE DEAN
Okkarunga.

Ragavan sits. He puts his phone face down on his own knee, not on the desk.

THE DEAN (CONT'D)
Vandheenga.

RAGAVAN
Pathu-nu sonneenga sir.

THE DEAN
Pathu mani-nu niraiya perukku sollirukken.

He turns the file round on the desk so that it faces the other chair, and pushes it two inches, and takes his hand off it.

INSERT — the top sheet. A column of subject codes down the left. A column of attempts. A column that is empty.

At the bottom of the empty column, a total, written in by hand in a clerk's blue ballpoint.

THE DEAN (CONT'D)
Pathinonnu.

Ragavan does not look down at the sheet. He has known that number longer than this room has.

RAGAVAN
Pathinonnu.

THE DEAN
Rendaam varushathil moonu.
Moonaavadhil naalu. Neenga varadhu
nirutina semester-il naalu.

THE DEAN (CONT'D)
Nethu en quad-il oru table-il ninga
irundheenga, hiring.

THE DEAN
Oru firm, file-il degree illaadha
oruvarai recruitment table-il
okkara vaikkaadhu.

A pause. Outside, a class changes and eighty pairs of feet go past the window and are gone.

THE DEAN (CONT'D)
Andha thaal enga irundhu
vandhadhu-nu naan kekka maatten.
Andha badhil indha arai-il enakku
vendaam.

RAGAVAN
Apo indha room la enna venum sir?

THE DEAN
Onnum illai. Naan ungalai edhuvum
kekkavillai.

He says it the way he would say the fees are due on the fourth. There is no weight on it at all.

RAGAVAN
Sir, ungalukku enna theriyum. First
year la irundhu.

THE DEAN
Aam.

RAGAVAN

Apo theriyum, naan office la okkandhu yaarkittayum thirudala. Velai panren. Velaila nalla irukken.

THE DEAN
Naan nambukiren.

That lands harder than a refusal would. Every version he rehearsed in the car assumed he would not be believed.

THE DEAN (CONT'D)
Supplementary sittings indha term muzhuvadhum nadakkum. Term-il moonu maasam irukku. Kadaisi paper kadaisi Velli.

THE DEAN
Moonu maasam, pathinonnu paper. Clear pannunga, indha college ungalukku sariyaana thedhiyodu adhai tharum.

RAGAVAN
Clear pannalanna?

THE DEAN
Apo thingal anru unga employer-ukkum university-kkum naan ezhudhuven, andha order-il.

He opens a drawer, takes out a pad, writes two lines on it and tears the sheet off. He does not hand it over yet.

RAGAVAN
Naan client account la irukken sir. Sunday calls. Adha panindu moonu maasathil pathinonnu paper ezhudha mudiyadhu.

THE DEAN
Illai. Mudiyaadhu.

The flat agreement is worse than an argument. Ragavan sits with it, then finds the question under the question.

RAGAVAN
Enakku yen moonu maasam?

THE DEAN
Thirumba sollunga.

RAGAVAN
Nethu saayangaalam oru phone call panni irukkalaam. Yen pannala?

The Dean closes the file. It is the only slightly human movement he makes in the scene and it is over in a second.

THE DEAN
Neenga innum rolls-il irukkeenga.

THE DEAN
Yaarum ungalai neekkavillai. Neenga varadhu nirutineergal; adhu office ungalukkaaga edukkum mudivu illai. Neenga indha college-in registered student, pathinonnu paper baaki.

RAGAVAN
Adhu oru clerical error sir.

THE DEAN
Adhu dhaan rule. Rolls-il irukkum maanavarukku ezhudha urimai undu. Enakku pidicha paadhiyai mattum naan amaippadhillai.

He gets up, goes to the wall, and turns the calendar sheet so the lower half is uppermost. He puts one finger on the last Friday of the third month.

THE DEAN (CONT'D)
Sittings-ukkaana registration pathinaangaam thedhi mudiyum. Clerk keezha naalu mani varai irupaar.

RAGAVAN
Adhu varaikkum neenga adha vechiruppeengala?

THE DEAN
Adhu varai naan onnume seyya maatten. Adhu dhayai illai. Adhu dhaan moonu maasam.

He comes back to the desk and holds out the torn sheet.

INSERT — two lines in a very small, very level hand. A date. And under the date, a number, and the number is eleven.

Ragavan folds it once and puts it in the pocket the ring box was in.

RAGAVAN
Sir. Naan clear pannitta, file la munnadi enna irundhadhu-nu yaarkittayum sollanuma?

The Dean sits down and pulls the next folder across from a stack of next folders.

THE DEAN
Adhu, neenga yaarukku adha kaatteengalo, avangalukkaana kelvi.

He opens the next file and starts to read it. The interview is over and nobody has said that it is.

Ragavan stands. At the door he stops, because he is a man who always has one more thing, and for once he does not have it.

The lamp with the green shade is still burning in a room full of daylight.

EXT. ENGINEERING COLLEGE — FRONT BLOCK - DAY

The front block steps, where a hundred and ten students sit and stand between hours because there is shade and nothing else to do.

Under the arch, a counter with a grille over it and a wooden ledge worn pale in two places by elbows.

A queue of nine first and second years in the standard shirt. Last in the queue, in office trousers and a laptop bag, RAGAVAN.

The COLLEGE CLERK works behind the grille without looking up through it. He is dealing with the queue at the rate of one student every ninety seconds.

COLLEGE CLERK
Form.

A printed sheet comes under the grille with two carbons stapled behind it. Blue top, pink, yellow.

COLLEGE CLERK (CONT'D)
Azhuthi ezhudhunga. Yellow copy dhaan mukkiyam.

He fills it on the ledge, standing, with a pen chained to the counter that will not reach the boxes on the right.

INSERT — the form. Name. Register number, which he has to think about. Year of last attendance. And a box one inch wide headed REASON FOR DISCONTINUATION.

He looks at the inch for a while.

He writes two words in it. We do not see them.

COLLEGE CLERK
Photograph. Rendu, stamp size. Bus stop-ukku edhire studio irukku, arubadhu rubaa.

On the steps behind him somebody has turned round. Then somebody else.

A name goes along the step, not said to him, said about him, the way a name travels across a quad. It takes about four seconds to reach the far end.

Ragavan does not turn round and does not stop writing. His ears have gone slightly red, which is new.

COLLEGE CLERK
Subject codes. Ellaamum. Handbook la varra order la, unga nyaabagathula varra order la illa.

INSERT — eleven ruled lines at the bottom of the form, numbered one to eleven, and under line eleven the printed words IF MORE, USE REVERSE.

Ragavan starts on line one and gets to line four.

He stops at line five the way a man stops on a stair that is not where he thought it was.

ANBU (O.S.)
Anju-aavadhu line heat and mass. Adha nee ezhudhave illa.

ANBU is standing at the end of the counter with a departmental register under his arm and a staff tag on a green cord.

Two years older. Same face. He does not come closer and he does not smile.

RAGAVAN
Unna staff aakitaanga.

ANBU
Teaching assistant aakirukkaanga.
Oru tag, kaasu kidaiyaadhu.

ANBU (CONT'D)
Nee anju-aavadhu line la.

He comes down the counter, takes the pen out of Ragavan's hand, and writes lines five to eleven without asking what they are.

He does not look anything up. He has carried the list for two years in the same place he carried it when it was fresh.

ANBU (CONT'D)
Pathinonnu.

RAGAVAN
Enna-nu enakku theriyum.

ANBU
Onnu koodaa unakku theriyadhu.
Eppovum yaaro dhaan sollanum.

The clerk pushes a second slip under the grille without being asked.

COLLEGE CLERK
Challan. Paper onnukku ettunooru ambadhu. Bank la kattunga, inga illa. Stamped copy naalukku munnadi.

RAGAVAN
Ettunooru ambadhu into pathinonnu.

COLLEGE CLERK
Onbadhaayiram munnooru ambadhu.
Keezha print aagirukku.

It is printed at the bottom. Somebody has done this sum before, on a form designed for people who have eleven of them.

ANBU
Moonu maasam leave edukka mudiyuma?

RAGAVAN
Mudiyaadhu.

ANBU
Apo epdi panna porae?

Ragavan folds the yellow copy, the one that counts, and puts it in the laptop bag between two things from the office.

He does not answer. Anbu lets it go, which he has never once done before.

On the steps, a hundred and ten students watch a man in office trousers walk down them with a fee challan in his hand, and nobody says the name again.

INT. CORPORATE OFFICE — OPEN FLOOR - NIGHT

The ceiling panels are off. Eight desk lamps are on across fifty five desks, in no pattern, like houses on a hill.

Two housekeeping staff work down the far aisle, stacking chairs onto desks behind them.

At the end of the row by the aisle, under a lamp, RAGAVAN. The nameplate with the extra letter in it is still square to the walkway.

Two screens. The left one has the migration on it. The right one has been asleep so long it has gone black.

On the desk beside his keyboard, a photocopied page. Under the desk, a laptop bag with the zip open and more paper in it than a laptop.

A housekeeping man vacuums around his feet. Ragavan lifts both feet off the floor without looking down and puts them back after he has gone.

The clock on the wall says twenty to twelve.

He is not working on either screen. He is working on the photocopied page, with a pencil, and he has been on the same question for a long time.

The lift at the far end opens. PALLAVI comes down the aisle with her bag still on her shoulder and her car key in her hand.

She is not surprised to find him. She has seen his car in the basement.

PALLAVI
Sunday note.

RAGAVAN
Thursday-e anuppiten.

PALLAVI
Theriyum. Veetla oru manithiyaalam adhula dhaan irundhen.

She puts her phone on his desk, face up, with a document open on it, and turns it round with one finger the way he once turned a monitor.

INSERT — a table of figures. One row is circled in red on the screen itself.

PALLAVI (CONT'D)
Third region. Adha old window la carry pannirukkeenga.

Ragavan looks at it. He looks at it for longer than he needs to.

RAGAVAN
Adhu old window.

PALLAVI
Aama.

RAGAVAN
March la move panninaanga. Adha kandupidichadhe naan dhaan.

PALLAVI
Theriyum.

There is no edge on it. She is not accusing him of anything, she is telling him what is in the file.

PALLAVI (CONT'D)
Tuesday la irundhu adhu note la irukku. Wednesday anniki kooda yaarum pidikkala.

RAGAVAN
Pathu nimisham kudunga.

PALLAVI
Pannitten. Anuppa vandhen, sollardhukku illa.

She picks her phone back up. She does not sit down, because she is not staying, and she does not leave either.

The vacuum starts up two rows away. Neither of them says anything until it has gone past.

PALLAVI (CONT'D)
Saturday ezhu manikku vandheenga, ippovum inga irukkeenga. Meedhi neram enga pogudhu?

RAGAVAN
Edhoda meedhi neram enga pogudhu?

PALLAVI
Hours. Jaasti panreenga, output kuraiyudhu.

She reaches across for her bag strap and her hand goes down flat on the photocopied page, and she looks down, because anybody would.

INSERT — a question paper. Printed codes along the top. A subject name. The word SUPPLEMENTARY in brackets, and three hours written under it.

Half a second. Nothing in the room draws attention to it.

PALLAVI (CONT'D)
Idhu enna?

RAGAVAN
Campus drive la oru paiyan. Avanukku rendu baaki, veetla yaarum college poonadhilla.

PALLAVI
Neenga coaching panreenga.

RAGAVAN
Avan kekkardhukku munnadi padichu vekkiren. Aaru varusham aachu, ellaam marandhuten.

Every sentence is true except the first one, which is the one she needs.

Pallavi looks at the page a second time. Then she takes her hand off it.

PALLAVI
Veetla pannunga.

RAGAVAN
Panren.

PALLAVI

Seriously sollren. Andha paiyanukkaaga illa. Third region-ukkaaga.

She goes. Down the aisle, past the stacked chairs, into the lift, and the lift takes a while to come.

Ragavan sits. The two housekeeping staff finish the far side and switch their lamp off, and the floor loses another light.

The desk phone rings. A desk phone ringing at midnight on an empty floor is a loud object, and he picks it up on the second ring.

RAGAVAN
Yes sir. Aama — illa, pathinaangaam thedhi registration. Naan already list la irukken.

RAGAVAN (CONT'D)
Register number. Aama.

He says twelve characters, out of his head, without pausing in the middle.

Three weeks ago he had to stand at a counter and think about that number. He does not notice that he no longer has to.

RAGAVAN (CONT'D)
Thank you sir. Illa, onbadhukkulla varen.

He puts the phone down. He pulls the laptop bag up onto the desk and takes out what is in it instead of a laptop.

Mark sheets. He lays them out across the keyboard and the mouse mat and the edge of the desk, in a fan, under one lamp.

On the screen behind them, the migration goes on scrolling by itself, green, finishing clean, requiring nothing from anybody.

INT. COLLEGE CORRIDOR — ARREARS BOARD - DAY

A corridor of closed classroom doors. Four tube lights, one of them dead, so the light arrives in patches with a gap in the middle.

Between two doors, the notice board. Behind glass. A brass hasp, a padlock, a key held somewhere in the office by somebody nobody has met.

The glass holds the whole corridor in it. Doors, tubes, the length of the floor.

RAGAVAN comes down it alone. Office trousers, shirt with the sleeves folded twice, no lanyard. The lanyard is in his trouser pocket, wound around itself.

He stops short of the board, the way people stop short of a counter when they are not sure the counter is open.

Then he goes up to it.

INSERT — THE LIST. Four columns, printed small. Department, roll number, subject code, sitting. A date at the top that is nine days old.

Roll numbers run in order down the left. No names. The college stopped printing names some years ago and nobody has ever said why.

His number is in the second column, a third of the way down. Four subject codes beside it.

Four.

He takes a folded paper out of his shirt pocket. It has been folded and opened so many times that it opens by itself.

His own handwriting. Eleven subject codes, one under the other, written in one sitting with one pen.

Eleven of them, when he wrote the list. He wrote it in one sitting at a desk in an office, on a sheet of the company's paper, because that was the paper that was there.

Seven of them are struck through. The strokes are in different inks and different moods. Four are not struck through.

He holds the paper flat against the glass and lines his four up with the board's four.

MACRO — paper and print, one surface. Four codes in his hand, four codes in the college's. They agree.

Behind both of them, in the glass, his face. Twenty-six years old, in a corridor built for people six years younger.

He moves his thumb across to the sitting column.

Three of the four carry dates inside the term. He finds each one and his thumb stays on it a second, the way a thumb does when the news is survivable.

The fourth has no date.

Where a date should be, the sheet carries a line of smaller print. He reads it.

He reads it again.

MACRO — the line. It says the paper is offered once in the academic year, and it says which month, and the month has already been and gone.

He stands back from the glass. The patch of dead light is exactly where he is standing.

A clutch of students comes down the corridor, fast, mid-argument about something that is not this.

One of them glances at the board without breaking stride. None of them glances at him.

He steps aside anyway, out of their way, into the lit part.

Two of them stop at the board, find what they came for, and are gone in under four seconds.

His mouth opens. The old reflex, the turn of the head, the line already loaded for whoever is standing beside him.

Nobody is standing beside him.

He closes his mouth.

The dead tube stutters once, decides against it.

He folds the paper back along its old crease. The crease is soft as cloth now. It takes the fold without being asked.

Shirt pocket. He flattens it down with two fingers.

A last look at the glass. Then he walks back the way he came, and his shoes are the loudest thing in the corridor.

The board stays where it is. The glass gives up his reflection and goes back to holding an empty corridor.

INT. EXAM HALL, COLLEGE - DAY

Sixty desks in ten rows. Each one carries a strip of paper gummed to its corner with a roll number on it. The desks are the small kind, built for a smaller body.

A wall clock above the blackboard says 9:52. Four INVIGILATORS stand at the four corners of the room with their hands behind them, doing nothing, doing it well.

Candidates file in and find their numbers. Most of them are twenty. They come in with one pen and the clear plastic sleeve the college insists on.

RAGAVAN comes in last. Same shirt as the corridor, sleeves still folded, three pens.

He finds his strip. Row six. He gets into the desk the way a tall man gets into a small car, in two moves, and his knees stay where they are.

Two desks over and one back: THE CLASSMATE. Twenty-one, neat, a steel watch too big for his wrist, a hall ticket he has already laminated.

He nods at Ragavan. Ragavan nods back.

An invigilator goes down the rows with the booklets. He reads the printed serial off each cover and writes it against the roll number on a ledger sheet.

INSERT — THE COVER. Boxes for name, roll number, subject code, number of sheets used. A serial stamped in the top right in ink that has smudged on every copy.

Ragavan fills his boxes. Name, no trouble. Subject code, no trouble.

He stops at the roll number and writes it slowly, one digit at a time, like a man signing for something expensive.

The question papers come face down. Nobody touches them. Three minutes of sixty people not touching a piece of paper.

9:59. The second hand climbs.

A bell somewhere outside the room, flat and institutional, nothing like the one in his memory.

Sixty papers turn over at once. The sound is one sound.

Ragavan reads. His eyes go down the sheet and come back to the top and go down again.

The hall settles into noise: pens, paper, a chair leg, somebody breathing through their mouth.

He is not writing. The man in front of him is on his second side already.

He finds question seven. He knows question seven. He has known question seven for six years without ever being asked it.

He starts there. His handwriting is terrible for four lines and then remembers itself.

TIME. The clock says 10:40. He is on his fourth side. He has gone back to question two.

He works. There is nobody to perform this for. No audience, no running count, no name being called across a canteen.

It is just a man at a small desk doing arithmetic he should have done at twenty.

He scratches out half a page with one long line and does it again underneath.

An invigilator walks the row and looks at his sheet without interest and walks on.

The Classmate writes steadily, left-handed, his wrist dragging through his own ink. He has not looked up once.

11:15. Ragavan's hand cramps. He puts the pen down and opens and closes his fist under the desk where it cannot be seen.

He picks the pen up.

11:30. Somebody at the back asks for water and is given it, and sixty heads come up and go down again.

He turns back to question four, which he has left a gap for, and the gap is still a gap.

He writes what he knows of it. It is a third of an answer and he writes it anyway, because a third is more than nothing and nothing is what he brought last time.

11:48. The invigilator at the front has started reading the ledger sheet to himself out of boredom, serial by serial.

Ragavan hears it the way you hear a tap in another room.

A candidate two rows up is taken out for something in his sleeve. It takes forty seconds and the room barely registers it.

Ragavan does not look up. His pen keeps going. That is new.

He has stopped checking the clock. It is the first examination of his life in which he is going to run out of time rather than out of material.

TIME. 12:05. He raises two fingers without looking up. An additional sheet arrives. He ties it in with the string and keeps going.

He reaches the end of a derivation and the number at the bottom is a whole number.

He looks at it.

He underlines it once, which is all a correct answer gets, and moves on, and there is nobody in the room who knows that anything happened.

12:50. An invigilator calls ten minutes. Three candidates start writing much faster and one stops altogether.

Ragavan ties his string and writes the number of sheets used in the box on the cover. He counts them twice to write it.

The bell. Pens down, booklets up, the sound of sixty strings being knotted.

The invigilator comes along the row and takes his, reads the serial, ticks the ledger, moves on.

Ragavan unfolds himself out of the desk. His knee has gone. He stands holding the desk for a second and nobody sees that either.

Outside, the corridor takes sixty people arguing about the same paper. Ragavan comes out into it and keeps walking.

Sixty people arguing about the same paper in the same corridor. Ragavan comes out into it and keeps walking.

THE CLASSMATE catches him up, half a step behind, the laminated hall ticket back in its sleeve.

THE CLASSMATE

Anna. Neenga company la irukkeenga la. Proper company.

RAGAVAN
Yen.

THE CLASSMATE
Medical ku date kudthuttanga anna. Pathinaalu.

He says the date the way people say a date they have been saying to themselves.

THE CLASSMATE (CONT'D)
Pre-employment medical nu podhirukku. Adhula enna check pannuvaanga?

RAGAVAN
Blood. Kannu. Jaundice vandhirukka nu kekuvaanga, nee enna sonnaalum no nu dhaan ezhudhuvaanga.

THE CLASSMATE
Kannu check pannuvaangala?

RAGAVAN
Glasses irundha problem illa. Antha floor la pathi per glasses dhaan.

The Classmate takes this in and puts it somewhere he can get at it later. The relief on him is out of all proportion to the information.

THE CLASSMATE
Amma kettaanga. Enna sollradhunu theriyala.

RAGAVAN
Kannu nalla irukkunu sollu.

They have reached the stairs. The Classmate checks the big steel watch.

THE CLASSMATE
Pathu past bus pidikkanum. Vittutta adutha bus oru mani neram.

He goes down two steps and turns around.

THE CLASSMATE (CONT'D)

Seven easy dhaane? Seven full ah ezhudhiten.

He does not wait for the answer. He takes the rest of the stairs two at a time, holding the sleeve with the hall ticket in it against his chest.

Ragavan stands at the top of the stairs with his cramped hand half open at his side.

Behind him, the hall. Through the open door, two men in uniform stacking sixty booklets in roll-number order and tying the stack with twine.

INT. COLLEGE CANTEEN - DAY

Three in the afternoon. The dead hour. Two of the long tables have been pushed together and nobody is sitting at them.

Steel tumblers upside down on a tray. A ceiling fan running at a speed that moves nothing.

ANBU is at the corner table with a notebook open in front of him, the same kind of notebook, the fourth or fifth of them. He never left.

RAGAVAN sits down opposite with two teas he has already paid for.

RAGAVAN
Moonu paper. Moonu mudiyum.

ANBU
Naalu.

RAGAVAN
Term la moonu. Naalavadhu date problem, en problem illa.

Anbu turns the notebook around and pushes it across, which is his whole argument and takes him no effort at all.

INSERT — a page ruled into columns in biro. Subject codes down one side, dates down the other. Seven lines have been struck off. Four have not.

ANBU
Keeleendhu rendaavadhu. Pakkathula enna irukkunu padi.

RAGAVAN
Board la padichiten.

ANBU
Apdina okkandhu thirumba padi.

Ragavan does not pick the notebook up. He looks at it where it is lying, which is a kind of reading.

ANBU (CONT'D)
Varushathuku oru thadava. August la poidichu. Adutha thadava un moonu maasam mudinja aprom.

RAGAVAN
Appo exception pannuvaanga.

ANBU
Unakkaa.

RAGAVAN
Case ku. Case lam irukku. Antha building la ellathukkum oru form irukku.

ANBU
Irukku. Avar sign panuvaar.

The fan turns. Ragavan drinks half the tea in one go because it gives his face something to do.

RAGAVAN
Moonu, seri. Moonaiyum sollikudu.

Anbu closes the notebook. Keeps his hand flat on it.

ANBU
Saayangaalam. Aarulendhu onbathare, inga, idhe table. Mudhal pathinonnu naal unakku pidikkaadhu.

RAGAVAN
Pathinonnu.

ANBU
Adhu oru number da. September la joke ah mudinjiduchu.

That lands. Ragavan lets it.

RAGAVAN
Adhuku enna venum unakku.

ANBU
Nee dhaan avakitta sollanum. Date print aagardhuku munnadi.

Ragavan starts to answer and what comes out is a question, because that is what has always come out.

RAGAVAN
Enna kekkanum sollu? Idhu summa en pending papers nu oru version um irukku.

ANBU
Apdina antha version ah sollu. Date print aagardhuku munnadi.

RAGAVAN
Cards already press la irukku.

ANBU
Appo press varaikkum time irukku.

He opens the notebook again, finds a clean page, and writes a line at the top of it. He says it out loud while he writes, which is the whole of Anbu.

ANBU (CONT'D)
Thingal la irundhu saayangaalam. Cards ku munnadi avan sollanum.

He puts a date in the margin. He puts a box next to it, empty, the size of a thumbnail.

RAGAVAN
En vaazhkai pathi nee box tick panna poray.

ANBU
Yaaraavadhu kanakku vaikkanum. Nee vaikka maattiye.

Ragavan takes the second tea, which has gone cold waiting, and drinks it anyway.

RAGAVAN
Naalavadhu paper.

Anbu caps the pen. It is the first thing he has done slowly.

ANBU
Naalavadhu paper pathi en kitta kekkaadha.

He does not say it hard. He says it the way you say a thing you have already decided and would rather not have to decide twice.

Ragavan nods. Keeps nodding slightly after the nod is finished.

Behind them the canteen staff start turning the tumblers the right way up for the evening, one after another, a small steady noise.

INT. EXAM HALL, COLLEGE - DAY

The same sixty desks, the second sitting of the day. The morning bundle is still on the front table, tied with twine, forty booklets deep.

Beside it the ledger sheet. Two columns in biro: the serial off each cover, the roll number it belongs to. A ruler laid across it to keep the eye on the line.

RAGAVAN in row six. Third sitting this week. He knows where the clock is without looking.

Two desks over and one back, THE CLASSMATE, same steel watch, same laminated sleeve squared to the corner of the desk.

INSERT — A BOOKLET, UNOPENED. A cover of folded card with the serial stamped top right. Two punched holes down the fold. Loose ruled leaves threaded through on a cotton string.

The bell. Sixty papers turn.

Ragavan reads the first question and the second and stops.

He reads the whole sheet. There is nothing on it he has ever been taught. This is the paper from the year he stopped going.

He fills the cover anyway. Name. Roll number, all of it, no hesitation now.

He writes. Four sides of handwriting that look from a distance exactly like four sides of an answer.

At the end of the fourth side he reads it back and he knows precisely what it is worth.

Two desks over, the Classmate turns a page and keeps going without lifting the pen.

Ragavan stops writing at 11:20 and spends the next hour and a half looking at the room.

The ledger with the ruler on it. The twine. The front table. The door to the corridor, propped with a brick because the latch is broken.

He is doing arithmetic. Not the arithmetic on the sheet in front of him.

12:50. Ten minutes called. He takes the cover and writes the number of sheets used in the box. He writes four.

Two desks over, the Classmate counts his leaves with a fingertip, twice, and writes twenty-two.

The bell. Strings knotted, booklets forward along the rows, the stack building on the front table.

An invigilator reads serials off the covers and ticks the ledger. He gets to Ragavan's and ticks it. He gets to the Classmate's and ticks it. They are one line apart.

The hall empties. The invigilator looks at the two bundles and then at the door and then at the only person in the room who is wearing office clothes.

He holds out the afternoon bundle and tips his head towards the corridor. Exam section, two floors down. No words are needed for this because Ragavan looks like a man who carries things for a living.

Ragavan takes it in both arms.

CUT TO:

A stairwell. Then an anteroom with a counter across it, a grille, and a brass bell on the counter with a slip of paper taped beside it that says RING ONCE.

Nobody behind the grille. A fan going somewhere out of sight.

Ragavan sets the bundle down on the counter.

He does not ring the bell.

INSERT — THE KNOT. One loop and a tuck. Somebody has tied forty of these today and stopped caring at about the fourth.

He pulls the end.

The bundle relaxes. He goes down the edge of the stack with his thumb, reading serials off the covers.

He finds his own. He lifts out the one under it too.

MACRO — two covers on the counter, side by side. Two serials, one line apart in the ledger upstairs. Two roll numbers in two different hands.

He unties the first string. The leaves come out of the cover in one soft stack.

He unties the second.

MACRO — four sides of writing in one hand. Twenty-two sides in another, left-handed, the ink dragged slightly at the start of every line.

He puts the twenty-two into his own cover. He puts the four into the other one.

The holes line up. They are punched by the same machine on every booklet in the building. The string goes back through without being asked twice.

He ties both. His hands are steady and that is the worst detail in the room.

Two boxes left. He takes out a pen.

MACRO — the box on his own cover. He turns the four into twenty-two. Two strokes.

MACRO — the box on the other cover. Twenty-two becomes four, under a single line of ink, the way a clerk corrects a clerk.

Four strokes of a pen in two boxes the size of a postage stamp. That is all of it. Everything else in the stack is genuine.

He slides both booklets back where they came from, in order, and draws the twine up.

He gets the knot wrong. He gets it wrong again. The third time it holds.

He rings the bell. Once.

A hand comes through the grille, finds the bundle, and takes it. There is no face with it and it does not count them.

CUT TO:

The front steps of the block. Late afternoon, the long light. THE CLASSMATE is sitting on the second step with the laminated sleeve on his knees.

He gets up when he sees Ragavan, like a man who has been waiting and does not want it to look like waiting.

THE CLASSMATE
Anna. Irubathi rendu sheet ezhudhiten. Kai poidichu.

RAGAVAN
Irubathi rendu.

THE CLASSMATE
Vaazhkailaye irubathi rendu ezhudhadhilla.

He lifts his writing hand and shows it, the ink along the side of the little finger, and he is proud of it, which is a thing people only show to somebody they have decided to like.

THE CLASSMATE (CONT'D)
Amma joining ku shoe vaangitaanga. Brown. Periya size ah edthaanga.

RAGAVAN
Oru size periya dhaan correct.

THE CLASSMATE
Avangalum adhedhaan sonnaanga.

He checks the big steel watch.

THE CLASSMATE (CONT'D)
Pathu past. Naan kelambren.

He goes down the steps and out along the drive at the particular trot of a man who cannot afford to miss a bus.

Ragavan sits down on the second step where the boy was sitting.

Across the drive, a window at ground level. The exam section. Through it, a trolley with forty bundles on it, and a man loading the forty-first.

INT. CORPORATE OFFICE — OPEN FLOOR - DAY

Fifty desks under a ceiling with no shadow in it. Everything on either side of the aisle is the same height.

On the third desk from the aisle, a sweet box, opened, the paper lifted back. It has been going around since half past ten and it is down to the ones nobody wants.

RAGAVAN at his desk with his sleeves down for once. People keep arriving at his shoulder in twos.

PALLAVI comes along the aisle with a stack of printed invitations held against her like a deck being carried to a meeting.

PROJECT LEAD stands up at the end of the row. He does not raise his voice. He raises a hand, and the floor goes quiet because this floor has been trained.

PROJECT LEAD
Rendu things. One, twenty-second confirm aagiduchu. Congratulations to both.

A round of applause of exactly the correct length. Somebody at the back whistles and stops, embarrassed.

PROJECT LEAD (CONT'D)
Two, adhanaala freeze fifteenth ku move aagudhu. Yaarum enga poradhukku munnadi migration sign off aaganum.

That is the whole announcement. An engagement and a code freeze, in the same breath, in the same tone, and nobody on the floor hears anything strange in it.

PROJECT LEAD (CONT'D)
Sweets antha desk la irukku. Romba nalla illa.

He sits down. The floor goes back to its noise.

PROJECT LEAD comes down the aisle on his way somewhere else and stops at Ragavan’s desk without sitting, which is how he has every conversation.

PROJECT LEAD
Client letter la first page la un peru irukku. Peru sollithaan kettaanga avanga.

RAGAVAN
March la naan phone eduthathaala dhaan.

PROJECT LEAD
Adhu work aagardhaala dhaan. Charming ah pesaadha, adhu tiring ah irukku.

He taps the desk twice with one knuckle.

PROJECT LEAD (CONT'D)
One more. HR files cleanup pannraanga. Un kitta edhu photocopy ah irukko, adhuku original venum avangaluku.

RAGAVAN
En kitta ellame photocopy dhaan. Ellaarukkum adhe dhaan.

PROJECT LEAD
Apdina innum nalla photocopy kudu. Adhu en department illa.

He is already walking.

Pallavi puts the stack of invitations on Ragavan's desk and squares it with two fingers.

PALLAVI
Naanooru. Appa naanooru order pannitaaru. Namakku theriyardhe irunooru per.

RAGAVAN
Apdina innum irunooru per panlaam.

INSERT — THE TOP CARD. Gold on cream. Two names, a date, a hall in Virugambakkam, and a line at the bottom asking for the blessing of those present.

PALLAVI
Kaalaila press ku poiduchu. Adhu dhaan last version. Idhuku aprom adhu summa paper dhaan.

Ragavan picks up the top card and holds on to it.

PALLAVI (CONT'D)
Un college vishayam. Antha papers. Ippo enna aachu.

RAGAVAN
Results irubadham thedhi.

PALLAVI
Irubadhu rendu naal munnadi.

RAGAVAN
Appo rendu naal munnadi dhaan.

She looks at him a second longer than the conversation needs — the face she uses on a status report she does not believe.

PALLAVI
Idhu poradhuku munnadi edhaavadhu sollanuma.

The floor. The applause two minutes gone. The sweet box with four left in it.

Ragavan smiles, and it is a good one, and it arrives inside a second, which is what he has instead of an answer.

RAGAVAN
Un appa irunooru extra ah order pannitaaru, adhu mattum.

She takes that. She has no reason on earth not to.

PALLAVI
Seri. Aarukkul freeze note ku sign.

She goes. Two desks down somebody stops her to say congratulations and she says thank you and keeps walking, which is also her.

On the desk, face down beside the invitations, Ragavan's phone buzzes against the laminate.

He turns it over.

INSERT — THE SCREEN. A number with no name on it. Below it, in small grey type, the same number again: three missed calls.

He knows the number. He put it in his pocket on the front steps of a college block three weeks ago and never saved it.

It stops ringing.

A COLLEAGUE arrives at his shoulder with a phone held up and an arm already going round him for a photograph.

Ragavan turns and gives the camera the face. It is a very good face. It has been working since he was nineteen.

On the desk, under the stack of four hundred cards, the phone starts again.

He puts his hand flat on it until it stops.

EXT. ENGINEERING COLLEGE — QUAD - NIGHT

The quad at nine. The blocks around it are dark except for one stairwell light on the third floor that nobody has ever switched off.

A single lamp on a pole near the flagpole. Everything the lamp can reach is grey and everything it cannot reach is nothing.

THE CLASSMATE is sitting on the low wall under it with a sheet of paper held in both hands. He has been there long enough to have stopped reading it.

RAGAVAN comes in from the gate side. Office trousers, lanyard off, car keys in his fist.

THE CLASSMATE
Sorry anna. Moonu thadava call panniten. Office nu theriyum.

RAGAVAN
Paravaalla.

THE CLASSMATE
Veetla yaarukkum indha words enna nu theriyala. Neenga ipdi oru company la dhaan.

He holds the sheet out. Ragavan takes it and turns it to the lamp.

INSERT — THE LETTER. A company letterhead. A reference number with the year in it. Four paragraphs, none of them longer than three lines.

MACRO — the second paragraph. The offer was subject to the candidate clearing all pending papers before the date of joining. The university has reported one paper not cleared.

MACRO — the third. The candidature stands withdrawn. Below it a sentence saying no further correspondence in this matter will be entertained.

THE CLASSMATE (CONT'D)
Edhu last vaakiyam. Entha sentence dhaan mudiya vaikkudhunu enakku theriyala.

He knows the paper code in the second paragraph. He has carried it folded in a shirt pocket for three months.

RAGAVAN
Moonaavadhu.

THE CLASSMATE
Moonaavadhu.

He nods several times, out of time with anything.

THE CLASSMATE (CONT'D)
Medical mudichiten. Pathinaalu thedhi. Kai la irundhu blood edthaanga. Kannu check pannaanga, fine ah irundhuchu. Neenga sonna maadhiri.

RAGAVAN
Nalladhu.

THE CLASSMATE
Office la solraanga, en booklet la naalu sheet dhaan irundhuchunu. Naan irubathi rendu ezhudhiten.

He says it without heat. He is certain of it.

THE CLASSMATE (CONT'D)
Antha section la yaaro thappu pannitaanga. Adhu mattum dhaan. Office la oru thappu.

There is a version of the next four seconds in which he says one sentence and all of this stops.

He folds the letter along the crease the company put in it, and hands it back.

RAGAVAN
Adhu form letter. Ellaarukkum adhe dhaan poidum.

THE CLASSMATE
Appo adhu maathalaam.

RAGAVAN
Exam section ku ezhudhu. Mela reference number, un roll number, exam thedhi. Vera onnum vendam. Feelings edhuvum vendam.

This is the thing he is best at in the world and here it is, doing nothing, at full strength.

THE CLASSMATE
Neenga paapeengala? Kudukardhuku munnadi. Avanga pesardhu theriyum la.

RAGAVAN
Enakku anuppu.

The Classmate puts the letter in his shirt pocket and buttons the pocket, which is a thing people do with documents they still believe in.

THE CLASSMATE
Amma theru muzhukka sollitaanga. Corner la irundhu rendaavadhu veedu, ellaarukkum theriyum.

He checks the steel watch out of habit and then remembers there is no bus to make tonight and nothing at the end of the ride if there were.

THE CLASSMATE (CONT'D)
Thingal anniku hall ticket kondu varen. Thingal paapaanga.

He goes. He goes at a normal speed, which is worse than any other speed he could have chosen.

Ragavan stands where he is until the footsteps are gone.

Then he sits down on the low wall, in the exact place the boy was sitting, and the wall is still warm from him.

He takes out the phone. The screen comes up white on his face.

He looks at it for a long time without touching it.

INT. DEAN'S OFFICE - DAY

A desk with nothing personal on it. A window facing a wall, which is why the lamp is on at noon. A student file, thick, with a rubber band that has cut a groove in it.

THE DEAN reads a result sheet. He reads all of it before he says anything, as he always has. RAGAVAN stands on the other side of the desk.

THE DEAN
Okkaru.

He sits.

THE DEAN (CONT'D)
Naalu paper, naalu pass. Kadaisi onnu special sitting, adhukku oru form irukkum. Naan antha form la sign panniyirukken.

INSERT — THE RESULT SHEET. Four codes, four marks, and nothing at all in the column where a pending paper would be.

THE DEAN (CONT'D)
Kadaisi paper la arubathi ettu. Antha sitting la adhigapatcham ezhubathi onnu.

RAGAVAN
Arubathi ettu.

THE DEAN
Nalla mark. Adhuku mela enakku vera abhiprayam ethuvum illai. Provisional certificate irubadham thedhi, kezha irukkura counter la. Irubadham thedhi odu college ku ungaloda velai mudinjidum.

RAGAVAN
Naan vandha paper enna aachu.

THE DEAN
Moonu maasathukku munnadi inga naan sonnadhu pathinonnu paper. Onnum illai. Naan appuram puthusa edhuvum serkka maatten. Unga company file la irukkardhu unga vishayam.

He says it as a reading of a rule. Nobody is offering anybody anything; a man is describing where the door is.

He opens the file and puts the loose things into it in order. A second sheet comes up and he sets it aside with the small irritation of administration.

THE DEAN (CONT'D)
Antha sitting la innoru vishayam, neenga hall la irundhadhaala solren. Thingakizhamai oru paiyan hall ticket odu vandhaan.

Ragavan says nothing at all. The Dean reads the rest of it off the sheet.

THE DEAN
Avan irubathi rendu sheet ezhudhinadhaa solraan, booklet la naalu dhaan vandhuchu. Exam section ku poachu, thalli vidapattadhu. Cover la kanakku naalu, ulla thaalum naalu. Serial ledger odu porundhudhu. Paper thanakku thaane sari nu solludhu.

RAGAVAN
Kattina aprom bundle ah yaaru check panraanga?

THE DEAN
Yaarum check pannuvadhu illai. Ledger dhaan check. Oruthar oru number ezhudhuvaar, innoruthar padippaar.

RAGAVAN
Adhu check illa.

THE DEAN
Naappadhu varusham idhu nindhirukku. Yaarum sodhikkaadha onnu, balamaana onnu — rendum onnu illai.

He says it about an office procedure. He has no idea he has said anything else.

He does not stand up.

RAGAVAN
Antha irubathi rendu thaal en booklet la irukku. Naan dhaan vechen. Naalu avanoda.

The Dean puts his pen down on the desk, parallel to the edge. That is the only thing that happens to his face.

THE DEAN
Innoru thadava, varisaiyaa. Enga, kaiyaala enna senjeenga.

RAGAVAN
Exam section counter. Bundle ah keezha kondu ponen. Avuthen, rendu cover ku naduvula thaal maathinen, rendu box la rendu number maathinen.

THE DEAN
Antha paiyanuku theriyaadhu.

RAGAVAN
Avan letter enna nu kettaan. Form letter nu sonnen.

He is sixty-one. He has heard most things in this room. Not this.

THE DEAN
Enakku ungala pathi santhosham illai. Adhai solli vekkiren, appuram illaadha oru anbai makkal kattikkuvaanga. Ippo kelunga, mudiyardhuku thalai aatta vendam. Naan kekkiren.

He counts them off on the desk, a fingertip for each one, not looking up.

THE DEAN (CONT'D)
Onnu. Indha office la irundhu university ku oru complaint. Unga naalu result um cancel, degree kedaiyaadhu. Rendu. Unga company file la irukkura certificate thani vishayam, adhu enakku illai. Adhu police ku poagum, innikke poagum. Moonu. Unga company verify panna ezhudhum, yaaro kettaa avanga eppovume adhai dhaan panraanga. Avanga kekkardhuku naan badhil solven. Naalu. Antha paiyan. Avanoda result thirumba kodukkappadum, section ku sila vaaram aagum.

He stops. Then he says the last one at exactly the volume of the other four.

THE DEAN (CONT'D)
Antha offer thirumba varaadhu. Adhukku form illai.

Ragavan does not nod.

THE DEAN (CONT'D)
Naalum purinjudhaa.

RAGAVAN
Aama.

THE DEAN
Innoru vishayam, unmai nu solren, offer panni solla illai. Ippo ezhundhu inga irundhu veliya poanga, naan edhaiyum thorakka maatten. Yaarum enkitta solla poradhu illai. Paper thanakku thaane sari nu solludhu.

He waits. He is not testing anything. He has described the situation, which is the only thing he has ever done.

RAGAVAN
Naan unga kitta solren.

The Dean opens the second drawer and takes out a printed form and a sheet of ruled paper.

THE DEAN
Unga kaiyaale ezhudhunga. Naan ungalukkaaga ezhudha maatten, neenga pesa pesa eduthukkavum maatten.

Ragavan writes. It takes a long time. He is slow because he keeps stopping to take the adjectives out.

At the end he turns the sheet around and pushes it across, and the Dean reads the whole of it the right way up before he says anything.

THE DEAN (CONT'D)
Antha file la naane kandupidikkaama vandha mudhal page idhu dhaan. List la onnum maaraadhu. Maarnudhunu nenachukittu neenga poradhu enakku pidikkaadhu.

He takes the rubber stamp, breathes on it once out of forty years of habit, and stamps the form himself, because the clerk's chair outside the door is empty. It is the loudest sound in the scene.

Ragavan stands. At the door he stops, because there is a thing people say here and he cannot find a version of it that is not a performance. He goes without saying it.

The Dean straightens the lamp back to where it was and opens the next file.

INT. CORPORATE OFFICE — GLASS MEETING ROOM - DAY

A room made of glass on three sides. Through it the floor, going on with its morning, twenty people at twenty desks, none of them looking in. A carafe with the seal still on it.

HR MANAGER sits with a personnel file open in front of him and a pen lying across the page. The same man who put a lanyard round Ragavan's neck in under four minutes.

PALLAVI is at the far end, her laptop shut, her hands flat on the lid. She is here because she runs the migration.

RAGAVAN sits where he is told to sit.

HR MANAGER
Verification nethu vandhiduchu. Record kaaga reference number ah read panren. Konjam periya number.

He reads the number out. It takes nine seconds and nobody interrupts him.

HR MANAGER (CONT'D)
University solludhu, antha varushamum vera entha varushamum apdi oru degree kodukkave illa nu. File la page four unga document dhaana?

RAGAVAN
Yes.

HR MANAGER
Made where.

RAGAVAN
Parrys Corner la oru print lane. Last la irundhu second shop.

HR MANAGER
Amount evlo.

The old reflex arrives on schedule — the better question, the one that turns a room. He does not use it.

RAGAVAN
Rendaayiram irunooru. Lamination edukkala.

HR MANAGER
So position idhu dhaan. Termination with cause, effective today. Access madhyaanam poidum. Lanyard indha table la irukkanum.

He ticks two boxes. He has filled this form in before, for other things.

HR MANAGER (CONT'D)
Client ku oru letter poagum. Naanga kuduthadhula first page la unga peru irukku. Avanga replacement name kekkuvaanga, avangaluku adhu kedaikkum.

Through the glass, somebody on the floor laughs at something on a screen. The glass takes the sound away and leaves the shape of it.

HR MANAGER (CONT'D)
For the record, file la unga work satisfactory nu irukku. Consistently. Idhula adhuku entha sambandhamum illa.

It is said as an administrative fact, flat, in passing, and it goes into him further than the termination did.

RAGAVAN
Purinjudhu.

The HR Manager turns the file around for a signature. Ragavan signs, and his signature is the only thing on that page that has always been genuine.

Pallavi opens the laptop. She has a list. She has had the list since six this morning.

PALLAVI

Work questions. Neenga poradhukku munnadi answer venum, straight ah venum.

RAGAVAN
Kelu.

PALLAVI
Entha sign-offs la neenga approver ah irukkeenga.

RAGAVAN
Onbadhu. Naalu enoda mattum. Meedhi anju la lead um irukkaaru.

PALLAVI
Neenga thottadhu edhaavadhu re-validate pannanuma.

RAGAVAN
Illa.

PALLAVI
Thirumba sollu, indha thadava yosichu sollu.

He thinks about it. It takes him four seconds and it is the most honest work he has done in this building.

RAGAVAN
Illa. Work sari. Ovvoru line um sari. Thappu irukkardhu antha pakkam illa.

PALLAVI
Freeze fifteenth ku dhaan move aagum. Unakkaaga naan date maathap poradhilla.

The HR Manager takes the signed sheet out through the glass door and does not shut it fully.

PALLAVI (CONT'D)
Floor la naan unkitta ketten. Kaila naanooru card irundhuchu.

RAGAVAN
Ketta.

PALLAVI

Ippo enkitta sollu. File version vendam. Un kitta irundhu oru thadava kekkanum.

He looks at her. There is no version of this that helps him, which is the first time that has been true.

RAGAVAN
Naan degree mudikkala. Oru certificate print pannen. Adhai vechu indha job vaangunen, adhai vechu indha job la nallaave irundhen.

He stops. The second half is harder than the first.

RAGAVAN (CONT'D)
Oru paiyanoda result ah naan edthuten, adhuku mattum enaala oru vaakiyam vekka mudiyala.

She takes it. She does not cry and she does not look away, and she does not give him anything either.

PALLAVI
Seri.

She puts the laptop under her arm.

PALLAVI (CONT'D)
Hall ku panam kattaachu. En appa hall ah cancel panna maattaaru, vaazhkailaye edhaiyum cancel pannadhilla. So irubathi rendam thedhi function nadakkum. Munnooru per varaanga, adhai naama solralaam illanaa gate la vera yaaraavadhu solluvaanga.

She goes. Through the glass she stops at the first desk and answers a question about something else, because the floor does not stop.

Ragavan sits alone in a glass room with a lanyard on the table in front of him.

He puts it in his shirt pocket out of habit, takes it out again, and puts it back on the table where it was told to stay.

INT. RAGAVAN'S HOUSE, VILLIVAKKAM - DAY

The front room, cleared for tomorrow. Twenty plastic chairs stacked in two towers against the wall. Borrowed vessels in a row by the door.

On the wall, the framed photograph. 2014, a boy on a stage, a box in his hands, two parents somewhere behind him out of focus.

RAGAVAN'S FATHER sits in the chair by the window. On the table in front of him, out of its envelope, the degree certificate. The paper has gone soft at the folds over seven years.

RAGAVAN stands. RAGAVAN'S MOTHER is in the kitchen doorway holding a vessel she is not doing anything with.

The father reads the certificate. He has had it in this house for seven years and this is the first time he has read it.

RAGAVAN'S FATHER
Seal enga irukku. Oru seal irukkanum illa.

RAGAVAN
Adhu print pannadhu. Mothamume print dhaan.

The father turns it over and looks at the back, which is blank, and turns it again.

RAGAVAN'S FATHER
Evlo aachu idhuku.

RAGAVAN
Rendaayiram irunooru.

The father takes that in. It is the first number in the conversation and he does what he has always done with a number, which is put it next to another one.

RAGAVAN'S FATHER
Fridge naalaayiram.

Nobody laughs. It is not a joke and it is not not a joke.

RAGAVAN'S MOTHER
Samaiyalkaarar advance vaangittaaru. En thambi varra train aarumanikku vandhudum.

RAGAVAN
Ma.

RAGAVAN'S MOTHER
Edhellam panam kattiyaachunu solren. Indha veetla yaaraavadhu kanakku vechukkanum.

She puts the vessel down on the floor with the others, exactly in line, because the line is the only thing she can still get right.

The father has not moved. He puts one finger on the certificate and slides it an inch away from himself.

RAGAVAN'S FATHER
Antha varusham, gate la, ellaaru munnaadiyum. Moonu vishayam sonnen.

He holds up one finger.

RAGAVAN'S FATHER (CONT'D)
Engineering.

The second finger comes up slower.

RAGAVAN'S FATHER (CONT'D)
Appuram masters, veliyoorula.

The third finger does not come up. His hand stays like that for a second and then goes back to the arm of the chair.

Nobody finishes it for him. The third item is a hall in Virugambakkam, tomorrow, at eleven.

The mother crosses to the shelf and opens the drawer under it. It is the drawer where this house keeps paper: the house documents, the ration card, two bank books tied with a rubber band.

The medal box is in there with them, flat under the bank books, where it has been since the year it was given.

She takes it out, wipes the lid on her sari out of habit, and puts it on the table.

MACRO — two objects on one table. A box with a school crest on the lid and a year under it. A sheet of printed paper with a name on it and no seal.

Nobody says anything about either of them. Nobody opens the box.

RAGAVAN
Naalaiku hall la, edhuvum aarambikkardhuku munnadi, naane adhai solliduven.

RAGAVAN'S MOTHER
Maalaiku munnadi. Aprom illa.

RAGAVAN
Munnadi.

She nods once and goes back into the kitchen, where there is a thing on the stove, and a minute later the sound of her doing it.

The father and the son in a room full of stacked chairs.

RAGAVAN
Thingakizhamai kaalaila Saidapet court ku poren. Sarandhaaga.

A long nothing.

RAGAVAN (CONT'D)
Kooda vaanga.

The father does not answer. He picks up the certificate, squares the folds, and puts it back into its envelope, which still has the company's reference stamped on the front from when they asked for the original.

He puts the envelope in the drawer. He leaves the medal box where it is, on the table, in the middle.

He shuts the drawer.

Ragavan waits at the door of the room for as long as a man can wait.

Then he goes.

RAGAVAN'S FATHER (O.S.)
Thingal enna mani.

Ragavan stops in the passage with his hand on the wall.

RAGAVAN
Pathu.

In the front room, the old man straightens the plastic chairs that are already straight.

INT. MARRIAGE HALL, VIRUGAMBAKKAM - DAY

Eleven in the morning. Three hundred chairs in rows, two thirds of them full and the rest filling. Ceiling fans in a line down the middle, all of them turning.

CRANE WIDE — the whole hall from the back. A stage at the far end, a flower backdrop, two chairs on it that nobody is sitting in yet.

A NADASWARAM PARTY of four at the side of the stage, playing. They have been playing for thirty-five minutes and they are paid until one.

On a table at the front of the stage, a brass tray with two garlands on it, and the printed invitation propped against a flower pot so the guests can check they are in the right hall.

RAGAVAN'S MOTHER in the second row with her brother, who has come straight from the station and still has his bag between his feet.

RAGAVAN'S FATHER stands at the end of the first row, not sitting, the way men of his age stand at functions.

PALLAVI is on the stage side in a silk saree with her hands empty. She has been awake since four. She knows everything in this scene except what he is going to do with it.

Near the back, standing, not seated with anybody: KEERTHI. She has not been in this film for six years and nobody on the stage has noticed her.

RAGAVAN comes up the three steps onto the stage. He is dressed for it. In his left hand, a long envelope.

A member of the hall staff lifts the garland tray and starts towards him.

Ragavan takes the microphone off its stand.

The nadaswaram does not stop, because nothing in a hall stops for one man with a microphone. He waits. Somebody at the side makes a flat hand at them and the music comes apart and ends.

Three hundred people and the fans.

RAGAVAN

Gate la kudutha card la en peru irukku. Yaaraavadhu maalai poduradhuku munnadi, rendu vishayam.

At the back somebody shushes a child. The ordinary settling noise of a hall being asked for attention.

RAGAVAN (CONT'D)
Naan degree mudikkala. Pathinonnu paper arrear irundhuchu, adhula sila paper ah indha maasam ezhudhi mudichen, irubathi aaru vayasula, paiyan ukkaara seitha bench la. Yezhu varusham naan velai paathadhu certificate vechu, Parrys Corner la oru lane la print pannadhu. Rendaayiram irunooru rupaai, lamination illaama.

The sound that goes through three hundred people is not a gasp. It is smaller and worse: chairs, and two hundred quiet sentences starting at once.

The mother does not move. Her brother looks at her and she does not look back at him.

RAGAVAN (CONT'D)
Rendaavadhu. Moonu vaaram munnadi, exam hall la, oru booklet la irundha thaal innoru cover ku maathinen.

He does not stop for the noise.

RAGAVAN (CONT'D)
En department la oru paiyan irubathi rendu thaal ezhudhinaan, avanukku naalu dhaan. Shoe vaangi vechirundhaan, antha velai poidhu. Avan amma theru muzhukka sollirundhaanga.

He stops there, not for effect. He has reached the end of what he can say in sentences.

RAGAVAN (CONT'D)
Thingakizhamai pathu manikku Saidapet court ku poren. Idhu dhaan ellame. Vera onnum varadhu.

He puts the microphone back on its stand, which takes him two tries.

The hall staff is still standing there with the brass tray and the two garlands, because nobody has told him anything different.

Ragavan lays the long envelope on the tray, in between the garlands, and the man holds it because holding it is his job.

MACRO — the tray. Two garlands and one envelope with a company reference stamped on the front of it.

Pallavi comes forward to the front of the stage. She does not take the microphone. She has never needed one in a meeting.

PALLAVI
Saapaadu kattiyaachu. Rendu pakkamum. Saapittu poanga.

It is the only instruction anybody in the hall has been given in four minutes, so the hall takes it, and three hundred people begin to stand up in the particular relief of having something to do.

She turns to him. Off the microphone, at the distance two people stand at when a hall is watching.

PALLAVI (CONT'D)
Idhai un pathina kadhaiya maathiradha.

RAGAVAN
Illa.

PALLAVI
Adhula nee kettikaaran. Adhu dhaan un best.

She goes down the steps on her own side of the stage, to her own people, and does not look back at him, and nobody in her family touches her.

The father has come up the three steps. He does not say anything to the hall and he does not say anything to his son.

He stands next to him, facing the same way, close enough that their sleeves are touching, and that is the whole of it.

The nadaswaram party, which has been told nothing, starts up again out of professional instinct. Two notes. Somebody makes the flat hand at them.

The hall empties the way halls do, slowly, in family-sized pieces, with the return gifts taken because the return gifts were paid for.

Hall staff start folding chairs from the back row forward, which is the sound of the function being over.

KEERTHI is at the bottom of the steps. Six years older than the last time he saw her and she has come up to the stage in no hurry at all.

KEERTHI
Anbu dhaan sonnaan. Naan varuvennu nenaikkala.

RAGAVAN
Vandhutta.

KEERTHI
Thingal ku aprom. Enna pannuva.

The old machinery starts up. Something warm, something that lands, something in under a second.

He lets it go past.

RAGAVAN
Enakku theriyadhu.

Keerthi looks at him for a moment. It is the first answer she has ever been given in this film.

KEERTHI
Seri.

She goes. She does not say anything else, because she asked a question and she got one, and that was all she ever wanted out of him.

CRANE WIDE — the hall from the back again. Three hundred chairs, half of them folded. The flower backdrop. Two men on the stage facing an empty room.

INT. DISTRICT COURT, SAIDAPET - DAY

A corridor with a stone floor and no air in it. Advocates in black and white going both ways with bundles tied in cloth,

and families on the benches along the wall in their second-best clothes.

RAGAVAN'S FATHER sits on the end of the third bench with a cloth bag between his feet. RAGAVAN beside him, shirt tucked in, nothing in his hands at all.

THE DEAN comes down the corridor with a file under his arm, in the same clothes he wears to his office, because to him this is a working day with an item in it.

He stops in front of them. The father begins to get up and the Dean makes the smallest gesture, which stops him.

THE DEAN
Hall naalu. Peru kooppidamaattaanga, number dhaan. Number ah kelunga.

RAGAVAN'S FATHER
Evlo neram aagum.

THE DEAN
Onbadhu nimisham, edhuvum thallippoagaama irundhaa. Chinna vishayam. Thakaraaru onnum illai.

He goes in ahead of them, the way a man goes to a committee.

CUT TO:

HALL FOUR. A long room, high windows, two fans. A bench at the front with a brass nameplate on it, and a clerk below it with a register open.

Eight advocates on the front benches, doing their own paperwork until their own matters come up. Twenty-five people in the gallery, most of them here for something else.

A list is read. Numbers, not names. The fourth number on the list is called twice because nobody answers the first time.

Ragavan stands up and goes to the front.

The bench asks whether he has had the charge explained and whether he is pleading of his own will.

RAGAVAN
Aamaam.

The bench asks it a second time, in the second form the procedure requires, which is whether anybody has promised him anything.

RAGAVAN
Illa. Yaarum illa.

It is written down. The sound of it being written down is the loudest thing in the hall.

The Dean is called. He goes up with the file and holds the certificate at the length a man holds a page he needs to read.

THE DEAN
Adhu en college kodukkura certificate illai. Paper um illai, vaarthaigalum illai, antha varusham naanga antha seal ah upayogikkala, enna, seal nu edhuvume illai.

He is asked whether the student is known to him.

THE DEAN (CONT'D)
Ettu varusham. Adhula moonu varusham en maanavan, anju varusham file la oru peru.

He is asked whether he has anything to say before the court takes up the question of sentence.

He does not look at Ragavan. He looks at the bench, which is where a man looks when he is giving evidence.

THE DEAN (CONT'D)
Idhu mattum, athuku aprom neethimandram enna venaalum seyyalaam. Idhai yaarum kandupidikkala. Audit illai, complaint illai, yaarukkum theriya vazhiye illai. Avan en room ku vandhu ennitta sonnaan. Idhai naan sollanum, enna, idhu unmai, inga vera yaarum idhai sollap poradhu illai.

He goes back to his place and sits down and opens his own file, because the next thing he has today is at two o clock.

Then the sentence. It is read out at the pace of a thing that is read out forty times a week.

A number of months. A fine, with the figure stated twice. A line about the four results being cancelled, which is a university matter noted for the record.

No music. No cutaway to anybody’s face. The camera stays where it is, and then it goes to the clerk.

INSERT — THE REGISTER. A ruled page. The clerk writes the number, the section, the sentence, and the name.

MACRO — the name. He has spelled it with one letter wrong. Nobody in the room is going to correct it, and in forty years nobody will have needed to.

The next number is called before Ragavan has moved.

Two court staff take him towards a side door. It is not dramatic. One of them has the manner of a man moving a chair.

At the door Ragavan looks back once, into the gallery, and his father is standing up in the third row with the cloth bag in both hands.

CUT TO:

A counter on the ground floor with a grille and a queue of four. A board above it in two languages.

RAGAVAN'S FATHER is at the back of the queue with the bag open. He has been in queues all his life and he knows how to stand in one.

He counts the notes twice before he gets to the window, and then once more at the window, because the man behind the grille waits for him to.

INSERT — THE RECEIPT. A printed counterfoil, carbon behind it, the amount written in by hand and the date stamped.

MACRO — the stamp coming down on it. Wet ink, slightly crooked, a round seal with the name of the court in it.

The father takes the receipt and looks at it for a long moment, and it is a document, and every word on it is true.

He folds it once and puts it in his shirt pocket, buttons the pocket, and picks up the bag.

THE DEAN is in the corridor on his way out, file under his arm, already late for the thing at two.

The father looks around the corridor without a question on his face, the way a man does when he does not want to ask one.

The Dean points, with two fingers, at the stairs down to the gate. Then he goes.

In hall four, through the open door, a number is being called twice because nobody has answered the first time.

EXT. T. NAGAR STREETS — DELIVERY ROUTE - DAY

Half past six. The shutters are down the whole length of the road and the road still has its night on it.

The light comes in flat from one end, along the tarmac, under everything, the way it only does for about forty minutes.

A two-wheeler at the kerb. Not new. A rubber strap holding the number plate on where the bracket used to be.

On the carrier behind the seat, a square insulated bag. The agency colour has gone chalky at the corners and the zip has been replaced once.

RAGAVAN. Thinner than we have seen him. Hair short, for the helmet. A shirt that is his own, because the agency does not give one.

There is no lanyard. There is no name on anything he is wearing.

He pulls the strap across the bag and tests it with two fingers, and then tests it again, which is a thing he does with everything he is responsible for now.

The phone goes into a clamp on the handlebar. A list comes up on it.

He puts the helmet on. The visor is scratched in a long arc across the middle and he looks through the part below it.

FIRST PICKUP. A shutter three quarters up with a light on inside. He ducks under it.

A man is packing at a counter, taking his time. Ragavan waits with his hands behind him and does not hurry him.

He reads a code off the phone. The man reads it back off a docket. They agree, and that is the whole transaction.

Out. The parcel into the bag, the zip, the strap.

LONG LENS FROM THE CAMERA CAR. He comes out of the traffic in the far lane, holds for a moment, and the traffic takes him back.

The lanes narrow as the morning fills them. Cloth on one side, steel on the other, a hand cart taking the whole width and nobody behind it in a hurry.

He goes down an inch of gap on the left of a bus, both feet out, slower than walking pace.

A building with three gates and the same number painted on two of them.

He parks and walks it. He asks at the first floor. The first floor sends him to the second. The second sends him back down to the first.

MACRO — the phone in his hand. The timer on the order has gone from grey to red.

He looks at it. He does not argue with it, and there is nobody to argue with.

He finds the door on the third try, at the back, past a parked scooter and a line of washing.

The door opens six inches. A hand comes out. He unzips, finds the parcel, puts it in the hand.

The door shuts while he is still finishing a sentence. He finishes it anyway, to the door, out of habit.

He marks it delivered. The counter at the top of the screen moves by one.

Four floors down, no lift, two steps at a time, because the next one is already on the list.

MIDDAY. The street at its fullest. The heat coming off the road in a way the long lens can see.

He eats standing up beside the bike, out of paper, in about nine minutes. He eats fast because of the list and not because he is hungry.

He drinks from his own bottle, which he refills from a tap at the side of a shop, and he asks before he does it.

A schoolboy stops beside him and asks for a lane. He knows the lane. He points with the whole hand and says it twice.

The boy goes. It cost nothing and nobody saw it and it is the first thing today that was not on the list.

AFTERNOON. A corporate tower on the main road. Glass to the pavement, a ramp, a security desk inside the doors.

He is pointed at a strip of tape on the floor outside the turnstile, and he stands behind it, holding the parcel.

Through the glass: a lift lobby. Beyond it a floor with no shadow anywhere in it and about fifty desks at the same height.

A man comes down for the parcel. He is wearing a lanyard with his photograph on it and the photograph is three years old.

He takes the parcel, says something pleasant, and goes back in through the turnstile, which closes behind him with a small sound.

Ragavan stands behind the tape with his hands empty.

He stays there for about four seconds, which is how long it takes the man to reach the lift.

There is no reaction shot. Nobody films his face. The camera is a hundred and fifty feet away in a car and it stays on the ramp.

He turns around, walks down the ramp, and gets back on the bike.

A shop front further along, closed for the hour, with a rate card behind glass. Printed prices in a column, the small ones at the bottom.

He stops at it. He uses the glass to check the strap across the bag.

The glass has the street in it, and the rate card, and him. He looks at the strap. He does not look at his face.

He gets back on.

A signal. Forty riders across three lanes, all of them with something strapped on the back, all of them with the engine off.

He is one of the forty. Nothing about him is different from the man on his right, and nothing about the man on his right is different from him.

The signal changes. The sound of forty kick-starts.

LATE AFTERNOON. A lane he has been down four times today. One tea stall, a bench outside it, a cat under the bench.

He parks without looking for a place to park.

The stall man is pouring for somebody else. He lifts his chin at Ragavan about four inches. Nothing is said, in either direction.

Behind the counter there is a nail in the wooden post. Hanging on the nail by its rim, upside down, a steel tumbler.

The stall man takes it off the nail without being asked and fills it.

MACRO — THE TUMBLER. Plain steel, dented on one side, the rim gone slightly out of round. There is no name on it. There is no name anywhere on it.

It is not one of the stall's tumblers. The stall's tumblers are in a tray at the front, twenty of them, stacked.

This one lives on that nail. It has hung there about five months. Nobody wrote it down anywhere and nobody checks it.

He drinks it standing, in four goes, looking down the lane at nothing.

No money changes hands. No money has ever changed hands for this one, and no money is going to.

He carries it to the tap at the side, rinses it himself, and shakes it out twice.

He reaches over the counter and hangs it back on the nail, rim down, where it was.

INSERT — the nail, and the tumbler on it, and the post, and the lane going on behind.

Somewhere in a drawer in Villivakkam there is a box with a school crest on the lid and his name engraved inside it. Nobody has opened it in eleven years.

He gets back on the bike.

EVENING. The light going along the road. Shop lights coming on in the order the shopkeepers reach the switches, so the street lights itself one frontage at a time.

He stops at the top of the lane and looks at the phone in the clamp.

MACRO — THE SCREEN. A number at the top of it, under the word for the day total. The number is eleven.

Eleven.

He looks at it for a second and a half. It is not a punchline and it is not a workload. It is eleven deliveries.

He taps the twelfth. An address comes up, a lane he knows, nine minutes away in this traffic.

He puts both hands on the bars.

LONG LENS FROM THE CAMERA CAR. He pulls out into the road, and the traffic takes him, and gives him back, and takes him again.

Buses. A hoarding for something nobody needs. A flyover carrying a different set of people over the top of all of it.

He goes down the length of the road, getting smaller in it, one rider among forty, with a strap he checked twice and a tumbler on a nail behind him.

He does not look back. There is nothing behind him on this road to look back at.

The traffic closes over the place where he was. The street goes on, full of people on their way somewhere, none of whom have ever heard of him.

FADE OUT.